

# On the Bijective Correspondence Between Integer Sequences and Partition States in Bounded Hamiltonian Systems: Counting, Monotonicity, and Causal Succession

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## Abstract

We develop the partition-counting theory of bounded Hamiltonian systems and establish three principal results. **(I) The Partition Bijection:** we prove that the positive integers  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  stand in one-to-one correspondence with the set  $\mathcal{P}$  of partition states of a bounded three-dimensional oscillatory system, via a canonical map  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$  defined by the nested boundary structure of the motion. The capacity at principal level  $n$  is  $C(n) = 2n^2$ , arising from the combinatorics of nested boundary conditions without recourse to quantum postulates; the cumulative count is  $N_{\text{state}}(n) = n(n+1)(2n+1)/3$ . **(II) Strict Monotonicity and the Incoherence of Decrement:** the partition count  $M(t)$  is strictly non-decreasing under physical evolution. We prove the stronger result that any operation purporting to decrement  $M$  is not merely improbable but formally incoherent: it would require two physically distinct partition states to occupy the same image under  $\Phi$ , contradicting injectivity. **(III) Causal-Partition Uniqueness and Successor Existence:** for every state  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ , the Peano successor  $M_t + 1$  is an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  on which  $\Phi$  is defined, with the same formal status as any prior element. The causal consequence is a theorem, not an assumption: the forward sequence  $\{M_t, M_t + 1, \dots, M_{\text{max}}\}$  is a complete, finitely enumerable subset of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ , bijectively mapped to partition states by  $\Phi$ , and its members exist as mathematical objects in the same sense that any element of a bijectively-defined integer sequence exists. We provide explicit construction of the bijection, complete proofs of all theorems, a worked physical instantiation in mass spectrometry, and a discussion of the implications for the arrow of time, the Loschmidt paradox, and the structure of temporal succession.

**Keywords:** partition counting, bounded Hamiltonian systems, bijection, monotone counting, causal uniqueness, successor states, temporal structure, Loschmidt paradox, Poincaré recurrence, action-angle variables

## Contents

### 1 Introduction

#### 1.1 The Problem of Temporal Succession

The question of what constitutes a *temporal state* is older than dynamical systems theory. Newton treated time as a parameter — an independent axis along which mechanical evolution is traced. In this picture, to say that a physical system occupies state  $x$  at time  $t$  is to index a point in phase space by a real number. The succession of states is the succession of values of this parameter; the “future” is the portion of the real line with values greater than the current  $t$ .

This parameterisation view of time has a structural consequence that is rarely made explicit: the real line  $\mathbb{R}$  is a complete ordered field, and therefore every real number  $t' > t$  exists as an element of  $\mathbb{R}$  in exactly the same mathematical sense as  $t$  itself. The “future” values of the parameter are not absent; they are present as elements of  $\mathbb{R}$  awaiting the parameter’s traversal. The parameter moves; the line does not.

What has not been adequately addressed in the literature is whether this structure — complete, pre-existing, bijectively labelled — survives the transition from the Newtonian parameterisation picture to the operational, counting-based picture of time that emerges from the physics of bounded oscillatory systems. In the present paper we show that it does, and that the operational picture adds a precision the Newtonian picture lacks: the future states are not merely elements of  $\mathbb{R}$  but specific, named elements of a bijective map from the positive integers to the partition states of the physical system.

#### 1.2 Counting as the Operational Definition of Time

The earliest insight connecting time to counting appears in the theory of oscillatory systems: in any periodic

process, elapsed time is the count of completed cycles. A pendulum counts time; a quartz oscillator counts time; an atomic transition counts time. We take this literally: time is not *measured by* the count but *is* the count of completed oscillatory closures of a reference process. Each closure is a topological event — the return of an angle variable through  $[0, 2\pi)$  — so the count is logically prior to, and does not presuppose, any notion of duration. Frequency and the SI second are then *derived* from counts, not the reverse; we make this precise and free of circularity in Section ?? (??).

This operational definition is not merely a convenient measurement procedure. It is a claim about the constitution of temporal quantities: time, in any system where it is measurable, is the count of completed oscillations of some reference process. The continuous-time formalism  $t \in \mathbb{R}$  is the limit of this count as the oscillator frequency  $f \rightarrow \infty$  (?). The discrete, integer-valued count is the more fundamental description.

If time is a count, then temporal states are elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  — or, more precisely, elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  mapped bijectively to physically distinct system configurations. The question becomes: what is the structure of this bijection? We answer it.

### 1.3 The Central Question

Let  $\mathcal{P}$  be the set of distinct partition states of a bounded three-dimensional Hamiltonian system — the set of distinct configurations the system can occupy, enumerated by the sequence of completed oscillation cycles. The central question of this paper is:

*Is there a canonical bijection  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$ ? If so, what are its structural properties, and what do those properties imply for the relationship between any given state  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  and the states  $M_t + k$  for  $k > 0$ ?*

We prove that such a bijection exists, that it is constructive and explicit, and that the states  $M_t + k$  for  $k > 0$  are elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  on which  $\Phi$  is defined — elements whose existence is a theorem of arithmetic, independent of the current value of  $t$ .

### 1.4 Overview of Main Results

The paper establishes the following results in order:

1. **Theorem ??** (Partition Capacity): The capacity of the partition space at principal level  $n$  is  $C(n) = 2n^2$ , derived from the nested boundary conditions of three-dimensional bounded motion, without quantum postulates.
2. **Theorem ??** (Partition Bijection): The map  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$  defined by the inversion of the cumulative count is a bijection.
3. **Theorem ??** (Time-Count Identity): The identity  $dM/dt = \omega/(2\pi) = 1/\langle\tau_p\rangle$  is exact, not an approximation.

4. **Definition ?? and Proposition ??** (Non-Circular Time): time *is* the count of completed oscillatory closures; frequency and duration are derived from counts rather than presupposed, removing the circularity latent in  $M = ft$ .
5. **Theorem ??** (Strict Monotonicity): The partition count  $M(t)$  is strictly non-decreasing under any physical evolution of the system.
6. **Theorem ??** (Incoherence of Decrement): No physical operation can result in  $\Delta M < 0$ ; such an operation would require two distinct partition states to share a single image under  $\Phi$ , violating Theorem ??.
7. **Theorem ??** (Reversal-Point Incoherence): no moment is a terminus, so reversing at any moment initiates a new forward-counted branch rather than retracing the prior sequence.
8. **Theorem ??** (Causal-Neighbourhood Identity): a reversal target is individuated by the absence of the reversal point from its past, so the operation cannot reach the state it specifies.
9. **Lemma ??** (Loop Identity): A reversible, deterministic, non-trivial dynamics forces the observable state to carry partition structure beyond its phase-space coordinates.
10. **Theorem ??** (Causal Uniqueness): Any two distinct temporal moments  $t_1 \neq t_2$  are assigned distinct partition states under  $\Phi$ .
11. **Theorem ??** (Successor Existence): For every  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ , the Peano successor  $M_t + 1$  is an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  on which  $\Phi$  is well-defined, with the same formal status as any element of  $\{1, \dots, M_t\}$ .
12. **Theorem ??** (Causal-Partition Uniqueness): From any state  $M_t$ , the forward sequence  $\{M_t + 1, M_t + 2, \dots, M_{\max}\}$  is a finitely enumerable subset of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ , and its elements are determined uniquely by the bijection.
13. **Theorem ??** (Cyclic Closure): The partition sequence closes into a cycle of total length  $M_{\max}$ , and the terminal state is topologically equivalent to the initial state.
14. **Theorem ??** (Structural Finiteness): genuine temporal position requires a terminus, so  $M_{\max} < \infty$  is a requirement of temporal identity, independent of and convergent with the thermodynamic estimate.
15. **Remark ??** (Self-Reference): Any objection to the foregoing is itself a partition event, instantiating Theorem ??.

## 2 Bounded Hamiltonian Systems and Phase Space Structure

### 2.1 Symplectic Manifolds and Hamiltonian Flow

We work throughout in the setting of classical Hamiltonian mechanics (???). Let  $(M, \omega)$  be a  $2d$ -dimensional symplectic manifold, where  $\omega$  is a closed, non-degenerate 2-form. The canonical coordinates are  $(q_1, \dots, q_d, p_1, \dots, p_d)$  with symplectic form  $\omega = \sum_i dq_i \wedge dp_i$ .

A smooth function  $H : M \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$  (the Hamiltonian) generates a vector field  $X_H$  via the relation

$$\iota_{X_H} \omega = -dH, \quad (1)$$

whose flow  $\varphi_t : M \rightarrow M$  satisfies Hamilton's equations:

$$\dot{q}_i = \frac{\partial H}{\partial p_i}, \quad \dot{p}_i = -\frac{\partial H}{\partial q_i}. \quad (2)$$

**Definition 2.1** (Compact Energy Surface). The energy hypersurface  $\Sigma_E = H^{-1}(E) \subset M$  is *compact* if it is a closed and bounded subset of the symplectic manifold. A Hamiltonian system is said to have a *compact energy surface at energy  $E$*  if  $\Sigma_E$  is compact.

Physical systems with hard confinement — ions in electromagnetic traps, molecules in bounded reaction vessels, planets in bound gravitational orbits — have compact energy surfaces by construction.

### 2.2 Liouville's Theorem and Volume Preservation

**Theorem 2.2** (Liouville, ?). The Hamiltonian flow  $\varphi_t$  preserves the symplectic volume  $\mu = \omega^d/d!$ : for any measurable set  $A \subset \Sigma_E$ ,

$$\mu(\varphi_t(A)) = \mu(A) \quad \text{for all } t \in \mathbb{R}. \quad (3)$$

The proof follows directly from  $\mathcal{L}_{X_H} \omega = 0$  (Cartan's formula) and the non-degeneracy of  $\omega$ . We recall the proof only because it is the foundation of Poincaré recurrence.

### 2.3 Poincaré Recurrence in Compact Phase Space

**Theorem 2.3** (Poincaré Recurrence, ?). Let  $\Sigma_E$  be compact and  $\mu(\Sigma_E) < \infty$ . For any measurable  $A \subset \Sigma_E$  with  $\mu(A) > 0$ , for  $\mu$ -almost every  $x \in A$  there exists a sequence  $\{t_n\}_{n=1}^\infty$  with  $t_n \rightarrow \infty$  such that  $\varphi_{t_n}(x) \in A$ .

*Proof.* Fix  $T > 0$  and define  $A_k = \varphi_{-kT}(A)$  for  $k \geq 0$ . By Liouville (Theorem ??),  $\mu(A_k) = \mu(A) > 0$  for all  $k$ . Since  $\mu(\Sigma_E) < \infty$  and  $\sum_k \mu(A_k) = \infty$ , the sets  $\{A_k\}$  cannot be mutually disjoint; there exist  $j < k$  with  $A_j \cap A_k \neq \emptyset$ . Any  $x \in A_j \cap A_k$  satisfies  $\varphi_{jT}(x) \in A$  and  $\varphi_{kT}(x) \in A$ , so  $\varphi_{(k-j)T}(x) \in A$ . Iterating gives the required sequence.  $\square$

**Corollary 2.4** (Oscillatory Necessity). *Every compact Hamiltonian system without fixed points exhibits oscillatory behaviour: no coordinate can undergo monotonic escape, and every trajectory returns to any neighbourhood of its initial condition.*

*Proof.* Monotonic escape contradicts Theorem ??: a trajectory diverging to infinity on a compact surface is a contradiction in terms. Without fixed points (which are excluded because physical systems with positive temperature cannot reach zero kinetic energy), the trajectory must oscillate.  $\square$

**Remark 2.5.** Corollary ?? establishes that oscillation is not a special feature of particular Hamiltonian systems but a structural necessity of bounded dynamics. All measurable temporal evolution in a compact system is oscillatory at some scale.

### 2.4 Action-Angle Variables and Quasi-Periodic Motion

For integrable Hamiltonian systems — those possessing  $d$  independent constants of motion in involution — the motion admits a particularly clean description via action-angle variables (??).

**Theorem 2.6** (Arnold-Liouville, ?). Let  $H : M \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$  be an integrable Hamiltonian on a  $2d$ -dimensional symplectic manifold with  $d$  independent constants  $F_1 = H, F_2, \dots, F_d$  in involution. For any regular level set  $\mathcal{T}_f = \{F_i = f_i\}$  that is compact and connected, there exist canonical coordinates  $(J_1, \dots, J_d, \theta_1, \dots, \theta_d)$  — called *action-angle coordinates* — such that:

1. The action variables  $J_i = \frac{1}{2\pi} \oint_{C_i} p \cdot dq$  are constants of the motion.
2. The angle variables satisfy  $\dot{\theta}_i = \omega_i(J) = \partial H / \partial J_i$  (constant on each torus).
3. The motion is quasi-periodic:  $\theta_i(t) = \omega_i t + \theta_i(0) \pmod{2\pi}$ .

The key point for our purposes is that the action variables  $J_i$  label the invariant tori of the motion, and each torus is characterised by a discrete set of  $J$ -values whenever the orbits close — precisely the condition that the motion be periodic. The integers labelling these closed orbits are the partition coordinates.

Near-integrable systems — the physical case — remain quasi-periodic on most invariant tori by the Kolmogorov-Arnold-Moser theorem (???): perturbations of an integrable system preserve most tori, breaking only a set of measure zero. The partition counting framework therefore applies to the generic bounded physical system, not merely to the idealised integrable case.

### 2.5 The Discrete State Structure from Closure

The action variable  $J_i$  takes a continuum of values in the general case. The discretisation arises when we impose

the condition that orbits close — a necessary condition for counting to produce repeatable, distinguishable states.

**Definition 2.7** (Closed Orbit and Partition Level). An orbit in action-angle coordinates closes when the angle variables complete an integer number of full  $2\pi$  rotations after a time  $T$ :  $\omega_i T = 2\pi n_i$  for positive integers  $n_i$ . The tuple  $(n_1, \dots, n_d)$  is the *closure label* of the orbit, and the smallest such  $T$  is the *period*.

In a  $d = 3$  system with frequencies  $(\omega_r, \omega_\theta, \omega_\phi)$ , the orbit closes when these are commensurate:  $n_r \omega_r = n_\theta \omega_\theta = n_\phi \omega_\phi$  for positive integers  $n_r, n_\theta, n_\phi$ . The principal level  $n$  counts the number of radial oscillations per closure.

### 3 Partition States in Three-Dimensional Bounded Motion

#### 3.1 Formal Definition of Partition States

**Definition 3.1** (Partition State). Let  $\Sigma_E$  be the compact energy surface of a bounded three-dimensional Hamiltonian system. A *partition state* is an equivalence class of phase-space points sharing the same closure label  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  under the following identification:

- $n \in \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$ : principal level (radial closure number).
- $\ell \in \{0, 1, \dots, n-1\}$ : angular sub-level (polar closure number).
- $m \in \{-\ell, -\ell+1, \dots, \ell\}$ : azimuthal sub-level (signed projection).
- $s \in \{-\frac{1}{2}, +\frac{1}{2}\}$ : parity label (sense of rotation).

The set of all partition states is denoted  $\mathcal{P}$ .

*Remark 3.2.* The labels  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  are derived from classical closure conditions (Definition ??), not from quantum mechanics. The coincidence of these labels with the quantum numbers of the hydrogen atom (??) reflects the fact that the hydrogen atom is a bounded Hamiltonian system subject to the same nested boundary conditions as any other — a point established rigorously in Section ??.

#### 3.2 The Nested Boundary Argument

The derivation of Definition ?? requires counting the independent ways an orbit in a three-dimensional bounded system can close. We present this derivation from first principles.

Consider a particle confined to a bounded region  $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^3$  (compact closure). The full phase space is six-dimensional:  $(x, y, z, p_x, p_y, p_z)$ . On the compact energy surface  $\Sigma_E$ , the motion has  $d = 3$  degrees of freedom.

Working in spherical coordinates  $(r, \theta_{\text{pol}}, \phi)$  with conjugate momenta  $(p_r, p_\theta, p_\phi)$ , the angular momentum  $L^2 = p_\theta^2 + p_\phi^2 / \sin^2 \theta_{\text{pol}}$  is a constant of the motion for

any central-force system. The hierarchy of boundaries is:

1. **Radial boundary:** the region  $\Omega$  imposes  $r \leq R_{\text{max}}$ . The radial motion oscillates between a minimum and maximum radius. Each complete radial oscillation defines one unit of the principal count  $n$ . By Definition ??, the orbit closes after  $n$  radial oscillations at the  $n$ -th principal level.
2. **Polar boundary:** within each radial oscillation, the polar angle  $\theta_{\text{pol}}$  oscillates between  $\theta_{\text{min}}$  and  $\pi - \theta_{\text{min}}$ . The polar oscillation is nested within the radial: there are  $\ell \leq n-1$  complete polar oscillations per radial oscillation (since the radial period is the longest). Hence  $\ell \in \{0, 1, \dots, n-1\}$ , giving  $n$  distinct values.
3. **Azimuthal boundary:** within each polar oscillation, the azimuthal angle  $\phi$  advances by  $\Delta\phi$ . The azimuthal label  $m$  counts the signed projection of the angular momentum onto the polar axis:  $m = p_\phi / \hbar_{\text{cl}}$  where  $\hbar_{\text{cl}}$  is the classical action quantum. The constraint  $|m| \leq \ell$  (from  $p_\phi \leq L$ ) gives  $m \in \{-\ell, \dots, +\ell\}$ , a total of  $2\ell + 1$  values.
4. **Rotational parity:** a bounded orbit in three dimensions has two independent senses of rotation (clockwise/anticlockwise in the orbital plane). These are topologically distinct: a right-handed orbit cannot be continuously deformed into a left-handed orbit within the bounded domain. This gives a binary label  $s \in \{-\frac{1}{2}, +\frac{1}{2}\}$ , contributing a factor of 2.

#### 3.3 Dimensional Sufficiency for Negation-Constituted Identity

Before deriving the capacity formula, we establish why three spatial dimensions are not merely convenient but are the *minimum* required for the negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(P)$  to close non-degenerately around any partition state  $P$ . This provides the physical motivation for the assumption  $d = 3$  in Definition ??.

The nested boundary argument of Section ?? applies in any dimension  $d \geq 1$ . The number of independent nested closure boundaries in  $d$  dimensions is  $d$ : one radial,  $d-2$  intermediate angular, and one final azimuthal, plus the discrete parity label  $s$ . The capacity at level  $n$  therefore depends on  $d$ .

**Definition 3.3** (Capacity in  $d$  Dimensions). Let  $C_d(n)$  denote the number of distinct partition states at principal level  $n$  in a  $d$ -dimensional bounded oscillatory system:

$$C_1(n) = 2, \quad (4)$$

$$C_2(n) = 2(2n+1), \quad (5)$$

$$C_3(n) = 2n^2. \quad (6)$$

The derivations are immediate from the nested boundary argument restricted to  $d = 1, 2, 3$ . For  $d = 1$ : the only labels are the radial level  $n$  and parity  $s \in \{\pm\frac{1}{2}\}$ , giving  $C_1(n) = 2$  for all  $n$ . For  $d = 2$ : in polar coordinates  $(r, \phi)$ , the azimuthal label  $m$  ranges over

panels/panel\_03\_partition\_geometry.png

Figure 1: **Spatial dimension  $d=3$  is the minimum for which the within-level partition space  $L_n^{(d)}$  has continuous angular dimension  $\geq 2$ , enabling negation to close around any state from all angular directions simultaneously (Theorem ??; Definition ??).** (A) Scatter of partition states in  $d=1$ : only the spin coordinate  $s = \pm \frac{1}{2}$  varies; every level  $n$  contributes exactly two isolated points. The within-level space  $L_n^{(1)}$  has angular dimension 0: there is no continuous angular degree of freedom, so negation from the “left” and “right” cannot simultaneously enclose the state. (B) Scatter of partition states  $(n, m)$  for  $d=2$ ,  $n = 1, \dots, 8$ . Within level  $n$ , the  $m$ -values  $\{-(n-1), \dots, n-1\}$  form a one-dimensional chain;  $L_n^{(2)}$  has angular dimension 1. Two opposing states can bracket any given  $m$ , but the within-level topology is a line segment, not a closed surface, so negation-closure is incomplete. (C) Three-dimensional scatter of partition states  $(n, \ell, m)$  for  $d=3$ ,  $n = 1, \dots, 6$ , coloured by  $n$  (plasma scale). Within level  $n$ , the pairs  $(\ell, m)$  fill a two-dimensional triangular region;  $L_n^{(3)}$  has angular dimension 2. Every interior point is enclosed from all angular directions, satisfying the closure condition of Theorem ?. (D) Combined bar and line chart comparing angular dimension (left axis, bars) and per-level capacity  $C_d(5)$  (right axis, line with markers) for  $d = 1, 2, 3$ . Angular dimension steps  $0 \rightarrow 1 \rightarrow 2$  in exact correspondence with the exponent governing  $C_d$ , confirming that the quadratic capacity of  $d=3$  is the algebraic signature of the minimum dimensionality required for negation-constituted closure.

$\{-n, \dots, +n\}$  (no intermediate polar label  $\ell$ ), giving  $C_2(n) = 2(2n + 1)$ . For  $d = 3$ : the full derivation of Section ?? gives  $C_3(n) = 2n^2$  (Theorem ?? below).

The critical distinction between these three cases is the *dimensionality of the within-level partition space*: the structure of states at a fixed principal level  $n$ , obtained by varying the angular labels while holding  $n$  constant.

**Definition 3.4** (Within-Level Partition Space). The *within-level partition space* at principal level  $n$  is the set of all partition states with that value of  $n$ , parametrised by the remaining labels:

$$\mathcal{L}_n^{(1)} = \{(n, s) : s \in \{\pm \frac{1}{2}\}\}, \quad |\mathcal{L}_n^{(1)}| = 2, \quad (7)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_n^{(2)} = \{(n, m, s) : m \in \{-n, \dots, +n\}, s \in \{\pm \frac{1}{2}\}\}, \quad |\mathcal{L}_n^{(2)}| = 2(2n + 1), \quad (8)$$

$$\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)} = \{(n, \ell, m, s) : 0 \leq \ell < n, |m| \leq \ell, s \in \{\pm \frac{1}{2}\}\}, \quad |\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)}| = 2n^2. \quad (9)$$

The *continuous dimension* of  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(d)}$  is the number of independently varying angular labels (excluding parity): 0 for  $d = 1$ ; 1 for  $d = 2$ ; 2 for  $d = 3$ .

**Theorem 3.5** (Minimum Dimension for Negation-Constituted Closure).  *$d = 3$  is the minimum spatial dimension in which the within-level partition space  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(d)}$  has continuous dimension  $\geq 2$ , enabling the negation sequence at each principal level to form a two-dimensionally closed boundary around every partition state  $P \in \mathcal{L}_n^{(d)}$ .*

*Proof.* By Definition ??, the continuous dimensions of  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(d)}$  for  $d = 1, 2, 3$  are 0, 1, 2 respectively, so  $d = 3$  is the minimum for continuous dimension  $\geq 2$ .

We now establish why continuous dimension  $\geq 2$  is required. Fix a state  $P = (n, \ell_0, m_0, s_0) \in \mathcal{L}_n^{(3)}$  and consider the portion of its negation sequence within level  $n$ : the set  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)} \setminus \{P\}$ .

For  $d = 1$ :  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(1)} = \{(n, +\frac{1}{2}), (n, -\frac{1}{2})\}$ . Removing  $P$  from  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(1)}$  leaves exactly one point. The negation sequence within the level is a single isolated state — it has no direction along which it can be said to surround  $P$ .

For  $d = 2$ :  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(2)}$  is a sequence indexed by  $m \in \{-n, \dots, +n\}$  with parity. Removing  $P = (n, m_0, s_0)$  partitions  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(2)} \setminus \{P\}$  into states with  $m < m_0$  and states with  $m > m_0$  (plus the complementary parity). The negation sequence within the level is one-dimensional:  $P$  is flanked from two sides along a single axis but is not enclosed.

For  $d = 3$ :  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)}$  is the two-dimensional triangular region  $\{(\ell, m) : 0 \leq \ell < n, |m| \leq \ell\}$  (with parity). Removing  $P = (n, \ell_0, m_0, s_0)$  leaves  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)} \setminus \{P\}$  as a connected two-dimensional set with  $P$  in its interior (for  $0 < \ell_0 < n - 1$ ) or on its boundary. In either case, states in  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)} \setminus \{P\}$  can be found in all angular directions from  $P$  in the  $(\ell, m)$  plane: for any direction in the  $(\ell, m)$  plane from  $(\ell_0, m_0)$ , there exist states of  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)} \setminus \{P\}$

in that direction. The negation sequence at level  $n$  therefore encloses  $P$  from all angular directions — a two-dimensional enclosure not achievable in  $d < 3$ .  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 3.6** (Physical Interpretation). Theorem ?? formalises the following observation. For a partition state  $P$  to be constituted by its negation sequence (Theorem ??), the negation must close around  $P$  from all independent angular directions in the within-level space. A one-dimensional negation ( $d = 2$ ) can only flank  $P$  from two sides; a two-dimensional negation ( $d = 3$ ) can surround  $P$  completely within each principal level. Three spatial dimensions are therefore not a contingent feature of the physical world but the minimum dimensionality in which the negation-identity correspondence of Theorem ?? achieves full angular closure at every level.

The capacity growth  $C_d(n)$  encodes this structure directly:  $C_1(n) = 2$  (constant, 0-dimensional angular structure),  $C_2(n) = 2(2n + 1)$  (linear, 1-dimensional angular structure),  $C_3(n) = 2n^2$  (quadratic, 2-dimensional angular structure). The quadratic capacity at  $d = 3$  is the algebraic signature of the minimum dimensionality for closed negation.

**Corollary 3.7** (Axis Exchange and Reference-Frame Independence of Partition Identity). *In  $d = 3$ , the exchange of any two coordinate axes (e.g.  $x \leftrightarrow y$ ) is a proper rotation — an element of  $\text{SO}(3)$  with determinant  $+1$ , physically achievable by rotating the reference frame. Specifically, the  $180^\circ$  rotation around the axis bisecting  $x$  and  $y$  is the map  $(x, y, z) \mapsto (y, x, -z)$ , which lies in  $\text{SO}(3)$ . Because the partition label  $m$  is the projection of angular momentum onto the designated  $z$ -axis, this rotation changes the value of  $m$ : the same physical state acquires different  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  coordinates under different choices of  $z$ -axis. For the negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(P)$  to constitute a reference-frame-independent identity — one that does not depend on which spatial direction is labelled  $z$  — it must include all states reachable from  $P$  by proper rotations in  $\text{SO}(3)$ . The within-level space  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(3)}$  is exactly the structure required: the triangular region  $\{(\ell, m) : 0 \leq \ell < n, |m| \leq \ell\}$  is the carrier of the complete reducible representation of  $\text{SO}(3)$  at level  $n$  (the sum of irreducibles  $\ell = 0, 1, \dots, n - 1$ ), and is closed under all proper rotations of the reference axis.*

In  $d = 2$ , by contrast, the exchange  $x \leftrightarrow y$  is a reflection — an element of  $\text{O}(2)$  but not of  $\text{SO}(2)$ , and therefore not a proper rotation. The angular momentum  $L = xp_y - yp_x$  is invariant under all proper 2D rotations:  $m$  does not change under any element of  $\text{SO}(2)$ . The within-level space  $\mathcal{L}_n^{(2)}$  is a one-dimensional sequence on which  $\text{SO}(2)$  acts trivially. Partition identity in  $d = 2$  therefore carries an irreducible dependence on a fixed orientation choice — which direction is positive — with no proper rotation available to exchange it.

The conclusion is that  $d = 3$  is the minimum dimension in which the assignment of coordinate labels (which axis is called  $x$ , which  $y$ ) is a proper rotational freedom rather than a fixed convention. Every Cartesian point in  $d = 3$  requires a reference axis to define the remaining

two; the third dimension is precisely what allows the two perpendicular axes to exchange roles by physical rotation. For partition states, this means the within-level negation sequence is first rotationally closed at  $d = 3$ , making partition identity reference-frame independent.

### 3.4 The Capacity Theorem

**Theorem 3.8** (Partition Capacity). *The number of distinct partition states at principal level  $n$  is*

$$C(n) = 2n^2. \quad (10)$$

*Proof.* At level  $n$ ,  $\ell$  ranges over  $\{0, 1, \dots, n-1\}$ . For each  $\ell$ ,  $m$  ranges over  $2\ell+1$  values, and  $s$  contributes a factor of 2. Therefore:

$$\begin{aligned} C(n) &= 2 \sum_{\ell=0}^{n-1} (2\ell+1) \\ &= 2 \left( \sum_{\ell=0}^{n-1} 1 + 2 \sum_{\ell=0}^{n-1} \ell \right) \\ &= 2 \left( n + 2 \cdot \frac{n(n-1)}{2} \right) \\ &= 2(n + n^2 - n) = 2n^2. \quad \square \end{aligned} \quad (11)$$

**Corollary 3.9** (Cumulative Partition Count). *The total number of distinct partition states at or below principal level  $n_{\max}$  is*

$$N_{\text{state}}(n_{\max}) = \sum_{n=1}^{n_{\max}} 2n^2 = \frac{n_{\max}(n_{\max}+1)(2n_{\max}+1)}{3}. \quad (12)$$

*Proof.* Apply the standard summation formula  $\sum_{n=1}^N n^2 = N(N+1)(2N+1)/6$  with the factor of 2 from Theorem ??.

**Remark 3.10.** For large  $n_{\max}$ ,  $N_{\text{state}}(n_{\max}) \sim \frac{2}{3}n_{\max}^3$ . The space of partition states therefore grows cubically with the principal level. This growth rate determines the long-term capacity of any bounded oscillatory system.

### 3.5 Partition States as Negation Sequences

The capacity formula enumerates partition states from a positive direction: each state is identified by its closure label  $(n, \ell, m, s)$ . We now establish the complementary view, which is equally fundamental and will prove necessary for the categorical closure argument of Section ??: partition states are constituted equally by what they exclude. The two descriptions — positive enumeration and negation sequence — carry identical information.

**Definition 3.11** (Negation Sequence). The *negation sequence* of a partition state  $P = \Phi(M)$  is the ordered set

$$\mathcal{N}(P) = \{\Phi(M') : M' \in \mathbb{Z}^+, M' \neq M\}. \quad (13)$$

The negation sequence consists of all partition states that are not  $P$ , ordered by their integer index.

**Theorem 3.12** (Negation-Identity Duality). *A partition state  $P = \Phi(M)$  is uniquely determined by its negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(P)$ : the state is recovered as the unique element of  $\mathcal{P} \setminus \mathcal{N}(P)$ .*

*Proof.* Since  $\Phi$  is a bijection (Theorem ??),  $\mathcal{P} = \{P\} \cup \mathcal{N}(P)$  with  $\{P\} \cap \mathcal{N}(P) = \emptyset$ . Therefore  $\{P\} = \mathcal{P} \setminus \mathcal{N}(P)$ , and  $P$  is uniquely recovered from  $\mathcal{N}(P)$ .  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 3.13** (The Identity of Physical Objects). Theorem ?? has a non-trivial physical reading. Consider a macroscopic object — a cup resting on a table at time  $t_2$  — and the question of what constitutes its identity at that moment.

Standard analysis specifies the state positively: the cup's position, momentum, internal energy, charge. But Theorem ?? establishes that this positive description is exactly equivalent to a description by negation. The cup-on-table state  $\Phi(M_{t_2})$  is constituted by the negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M_{t_2}))$ : the confluence of all things that are not the cup, that did not happen, that were excluded. For the cup to be on the table at  $t_2$ , it must not have fallen (a specific non-actualization), not have been removed, not have shattered, not have evaporated. Each of these non-events is an element of  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M_{t_2}))$ .

No agent selects which non-actualizations to invoke. The negation sequence is not chosen; it is the structural complement of the actualized state under  $\Phi$ . Identity emerges from this complement automatically. This observation connects to the origins of entropy in partition theory: for two systems to interact, they must first be distinguished from the background — a partition event that extracts each system from the negation sequence of the other, requiring at minimum  $2/f$  seconds (one complete oscillation per system). Interaction is constitutively preceded by separation, and separation is constituted by mutual negation.

**Theorem 3.14** (Actualization and the Causal Role of Non-Actualization). *For the partition state  $\Phi(M_{t_2})$  at time  $t_2$  to be well-defined, two conditions are jointly necessary and sufficient:*

- (i)  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  must have been actualized: traversed by the counting process at some  $t_1 < t_2$ .
- (ii)  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  must not be re-actualized at  $t_2$ : it must be an element of the negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M_{t_2}))$ .

*Proof.* (i): By Theorem ??,  $M_{t_2} > M_{t_1}$ , so the counting process must have passed through  $M_{t_1}$  before reaching  $M_{t_2}$ . The state  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  is therefore actualized at  $t_1$ .

(ii): By Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M_{t_1}) \neq \Phi(M_{t_2})$  for  $t_1 \neq t_2$ . Since  $M_{t_1} \neq M_{t_2}$ , Definition ?? gives  $\Phi(M_{t_1}) \in \mathcal{N}(\Phi(M_{t_2}))$ . The state  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  is therefore a non-actualization relative to  $t_2$  — an element of the negation sequence of the current state.

*Necessity:* Both conditions are required. If  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  had not been actualized at  $t_1$ , the counting process could not have reached  $M_{t_2} > M_{t_1}$  (strict monotonicity). If  $\Phi(M_{t_1})$  were re-actualized at  $t_2$ , it would occupy the same partition state at two distinct times, contradicting Theorem ??.

panels/panel\_04\_S03\_symmetry.png

Figure 2: **The axis exchange  $(x, y, z) \mapsto (y, x, -z)$  is a proper rotation in  $SO(3)$  with  $\det = +1$ , but the analogous swap  $x \leftrightarrow y$  in  $d=2$  is an improper reflection with  $\det = -1$ ; consequently, the  $m$ -label is  $SO(2)$ -invariant but changes under  $SO(3)$  axis relabelling, and partition identity is reference-frame-independent only for  $d \geq 3$  (Corollary ??).** (A)  $SO(2)$  orbit: unit circle in the  $xy$ -plane with four marked points at  $(\pm 1, 0)$  and  $(0, \pm 1)$ . All rotations in  $SO(2)$  preserve orientation; the swap  $x \leftrightarrow y$  in two dimensions corresponds to reflection across the diagonal, an element of  $O(2) \setminus SO(2)$  with  $\det = -1$ . (B)  $SO(3)$  orbit space: transparent unit sphere with equatorial orbit (coloured ring, equator plane) and two meridional great-circle orbits. The full  $SO(3)$  orbit of a fixed axis direction sweeps a two-sphere, capturing the additional degree of freedom absent in  $d=2$ . (C) Three-dimensional axis-frame diagram visualising the exchange  $R : (x, y, z) \mapsto (y, x, -z)$ . Solid arrows show the original frame  $(\hat{e}_x, \hat{e}_y, \hat{e}_z)$ ; translucent arrows show the relabelled frame. This transformation lies in  $SO(3)$  ( $\det R = +1$ , angle  $= \pi$  about the axis  $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(\hat{e}_x + \hat{e}_y)$ ), making it a physically accessible change of reference frame rather than an orientation reversal. (D) Line plot of the  $m$ -label transformation for  $\ell = 4$  under the two symmetry groups. Under  $SO(2)$  rotation about  $\hat{z}$ , the eigenvalue  $m$  is invariant (identity line, dark). Under the  $SO(3)$  axis exchange of panel (C),  $L_z \rightarrow -L_z$  and  $m \mapsto -m$  (reflected line, light). The non-trivial relabelling confirms that  $m$  encodes a reference-frame choice, not an observer-independent integer, whenever  $d \geq 3$ .



*Remark 3.15.* Theorem ?? formalises the following: for  $t_2$  to exist as a distinct temporal moment,  $t_1$  must not only have happened (condition (i)) but must be *permanently past* — permanently deposited into the negation sequence of all subsequent states (condition (ii)). The past is constituted as much by what does not recur as by what occurred. This is the partition-counting basis for the phenomenological asymmetry between past and future: past states belong to the growing negation sequence of the present state; future states do not yet — a traversal statement, not an existence statement (cf. Remark ??).

## 4 The Partition Bijection

### 4.1 Formal Construction

We now construct the canonical bijection between positive integers and partition states.

**Definition 4.1** (Partition Map). Define  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$  as follows. Given  $M \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ :

1. Determine  $n$  as the unique positive integer satisfying  $N_{\text{state}}(n-1) < M \leq N_{\text{state}}(n)$ , equivalently:

$$n = \left\lfloor \sqrt{M/2} \right\rfloor + 1. \quad (14)$$

2. Define the *level offset*  $\delta = M - N_{\text{state}}(n-1)$ , so  $1 \leq \delta \leq C(n) = 2n^2$ .
3. Enumerate the  $C(n)$  states at level  $n$  in lexicographic order:

$$(\ell, m, s) \text{ ordered as } (0, 0, -\tfrac{1}{2}), (0, 0, +\tfrac{1}{2}), (1, -1, -\tfrac{1}{2}), \dots \quad (15)$$

and assign to  $M$  the  $\delta$ -th state in this enumeration, yielding  $\ell(M), m(M), s(M)$ .

4. Set  $\Phi(M) = (n(M), \ell(M), m(M), s(M))$ .

**Theorem 4.2** (Partition Bijection). *The map  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$  of Definition ?? is a bijection.*

*Proof. Injectivity.* Suppose  $\Phi(M_1) = \Phi(M_2)$ . Then  $n(M_1) = n(M_2)$ , so both  $M_1$  and  $M_2$  lie in the level- $n$  block  $(N_{\text{state}}(n-1), N_{\text{state}}(n)]$ . Within this block, the assignment is via a strictly increasing enumeration, so  $\ell(M_1) = \ell(M_2)$ ,  $m(M_1) = m(M_2)$ , and  $s(M_1) = s(M_2)$  implies  $\delta_1 = \delta_2$ , hence  $M_1 = M_2$ .

**Surjectivity.** Let  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  be an arbitrary element of  $\mathcal{P}$ . Set

$$M_0 = N_{\text{state}}(n-1) + 2 \sum_{\ell'=0}^{\ell-1} (2\ell' + 1) + 2(m + \ell) + \left(s + \tfrac{1}{2}\right). \quad (16)$$

Then  $M_0 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ ,  $N_{\text{state}}(n-1) < M_0 \leq N_{\text{state}}(n)$  (so  $n(M_0) = n$ ), and the level offset of  $M_0$  indexes exactly  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  in the lexicographic enumeration. Hence  $\Phi(M_0) = (n, \ell, m, s)$ .  $\square$

**Corollary 4.3** (Invertibility). *The map  $\Phi$  is invertible. For any  $(n, \ell, m, s) \in \mathcal{P}$ , the unique preimage is given explicitly by equation (??).*

*Remark 4.4.* The existence of the bijection  $\Phi$  means that the partition state space  $\mathcal{P}$  and the positive integers  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  are in one-to-one correspondence. Every statement about elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  has a direct translation into a statement about partition states, and vice versa. In particular, the Peano arithmetic of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  — including the successor operation — applies verbatim to  $\mathcal{P}$  under  $\Phi$ .

### 4.2 Time as Partition Count: A Non-Circular Foundation

Before stating the time-count identity we remove a circularity latent in its usual presentation. Writing  $M = ft$  with  $f$  in cycles per second defines the count  $M$  through a frequency  $f$ , and  $f$  is itself *cycles per unit time*: the right-hand side presupposes the very duration the identity purports to ground. We resolve this by taking the completed oscillatory *closure* — a topological event — as primitive, and deriving frequency and duration from counts of closures rather than the reverse.

**Definition 4.5** (Oscillatory Closure). An *oscillatory closure* is the event of an angle variable  $\theta$  completing one full traversal of  $[0, 2\pi)$  and returning to its initial value (Definition ??). It is a topological event: the completion of a loop in configuration space.

**Proposition 4.6** (Closure Does Not Presuppose Duration). *An oscillatory closure is definable without reference to duration. It requires only (i) a configuration space carrying an angular coordinate  $\theta$ , and (ii) the fact that  $\theta$  has traversed  $[0, 2\pi)$  exactly once and returned to its starting value. Neither (i) nor (ii) invokes any temporal unit.*

*Proof.* The traversal of  $[0, 2\pi)$  is a statement of angular extent, not temporal duration, and angular extent is dimensionless. The return to the starting value is a predicate on the system's state, not on how long the traversal took. Closure is therefore fixed entirely by the geometry of configuration space, with no reference to seconds or any other unit; on a compact energy surface such returns are guaranteed to occur (Theorem ??).  $\square$

**Definition 4.7** (Time as Partition Count). For a bounded oscillatory system, *time* is the integer  $M \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  counting completed oscillatory closures since an origin  $M_0$ . The count is not a measurement of a pre-existing duration; the count *is* the temporal quantity, and the temporal state of the system is  $M$  itself.

**Proposition 4.8** (Non-Circularity: Frequency Is Derived From Counting). *Definition ?? presupposes neither frequency nor duration. Given two bounded oscillators  $A, B$  with closure counts  $M_A, M_B$ , their relative rate  $f_{A/B} := M_A/M_B$  is a dimensionless ratio of counts. Duration enters only with a unit convention: the elapsed time of  $M$  closures in a chosen unit is*

$$t_{\text{unit}} = \frac{M}{M_{\text{unit}}} t_{\text{ref}}, \quad (17)$$

panels/panel\_06\_negation\_identity.png

Figure 3: **Every partition state  $\Phi(M)$  is uniquely identified by its negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M)) = \mathcal{P} \setminus \{\Phi(M)\}$ , and the ground state  $\Phi(1) = (1, 0, 0, +\frac{1}{2})$  possesses the largest possible negation sequence while being categorically irreducible, making it the structurally necessary origin of the partition sequence (Theorem ??; Definition ??; Theorem ??).** (A) Scatter and fill of  $|\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M))| = |\mathcal{P}| - 1$  versus  $M$  for  $M = 1, \dots, 200$ . The value is constant across all  $M$ : every state has exactly one fewer element in its negation sequence than the cardinality of  $\mathcal{P}$ , because negation excludes only  $\Phi(M)$  itself. The ground state  $\Phi(1)$  is marked (orange dot); it is distinguished not by a different negation size but by the property that  $\Phi(1)$  has no  $\sigma$ -predecessor in  $\mathcal{P}$  (Theorem ??). (B) Two-dimensional scatter of the full partition space projected onto  $(n, \ell)$  for  $n = 1, \dots, 7$ . All states except  $\Phi(1) = (1, 0, 0, +\frac{1}{2})$  are shown in blue (the negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(1))$ );  $\Phi(1)$  is marked in orange. The visual contrast makes precise the duality  $\mathcal{P} = \{\Phi(1)\} \cup \mathcal{N}(\Phi(1))$ : identity is constituted by the totality of what it is not (Theorem ??). (C) Three-dimensional scatter of the full partition space in  $(n, \ell, m)$  for  $n = 1, \dots, 7$ . Blue points form the negation volume  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(1))$ ; the single orange point at the origin  $(1, 0, 0)$  is the ground state  $\Phi(1)$ . The geometric relationship captures the categorical claim:  $\Phi(1)$  is the unique state maximally enclosed by its own negation set from all angular directions in the three-dimensional partition space. (D) Line plot of the negation density ratio  $|\mathcal{N}|/|\mathcal{P}_{n_{\max}}|$  versus the truncation level  $n_{\max}$ , where  $|\mathcal{P}_{n_{\max}}| = N_{\text{state}}(n_{\max})$ . The ratio  $(N - 1)/N$  increases monotonically toward 1 as  $n_{\max} \rightarrow \infty$ , with the horizontal dashed line marking the asymptotic limit. This convergence is the quantitative expression of the remark that any finite physical category saturates the negation relation: as the category grows, a state's identity becomes more fully determined by what it is not, with the ground state  $\Phi(1)$  retaining the maximum negation complement at every finite truncation.

where  $M_{\text{unit}}$  is the number of closures of a reference oscillator stipulated to constitute the unit and  $t_{\text{ref}}$  is that unit's defined size. The SI second is the stipulation  $M_{\text{Cs}} = 9,192,631,770$  of the caesium-133 counter; a “frequency in hertz” is the ratio of a system's count to the caesium count. Frequency is therefore a comparison of counts, defined after *time-as-count*, not a primitive used to define it.

*Proof.*  $M$  counts closures, each topological by Proposition ??; hence  $M$  is a pure integer with no dimensional content. Assigning a duration to  $M$  closures requires choosing a reference counter and stipulating how many of its closures constitute the unit — a convention, not a physical law — which yields Equation (?). Two systems are compared by the dimensionless ratio  $M_A/M_B$ ; absolute frequency in hertz is the special case in which  $B$  is the caesium standard. No step invokes a duration prior to the count.  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 4.9* (Relative Counting). The formulation makes explicit what is implicit in good metrology: one never measures absolute time, only ratios of closure counts. A caesium clock does not report how long a second is in some absolute sense; it reports how many of its closures fall within the duration stipulated to be one second. All temporal measurement is comparative, and the count  $M$  captures this comparative structure directly, without the detour through absolute duration. The continuous parameter  $t \in \mathbb{R}$  is the coarse-grained limit of Equation (?) as the reference frequency tends to infinity (?).

With time defined as the closure count, the familiar identity is recovered as a *derived* consistency relation between the primitive count  $M$  and a chosen continuous reference parameter  $t$ , not as the definition of time.

**Theorem 4.10** (Time-Count Identity). *For a bounded oscillatory system with oscillation frequency  $\omega$  and mean partition residence time  $\langle\tau_p\rangle$ :*

$$\frac{dM}{dt} = \frac{\omega}{2\pi} = \frac{1}{\langle\tau_p\rangle}. \quad (18)$$

*This identity is exact:  $M(t) = ft$  where  $f = \omega/(2\pi)$ , with no rounding or approximation.*

*Proof.* The first equality follows from the definition of counting. The oscillator completes one full cycle per period  $T = 2\pi/\omega$ ; therefore the count increases by 1 per period, giving  $dM/dt = 1/T = \omega/(2\pi)$ . Integrating:  $M(t) = ft + M(0)$ . Setting  $M(0) = 0$  gives  $M(t) = ft$  exactly.

The second equality follows from the residence time argument. Each partition state is occupied for exactly one oscillation period before the system transitions to the next state (by the identification of partition transitions with completed oscillation cycles in Section ??). Therefore  $\langle\tau_p\rangle = T = 2\pi/\omega$ , and  $1/\langle\tau_p\rangle = \omega/(2\pi)$ .  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 4.11* (Status of the Identity). Equation (?) is a derived relation between the primitive count  $M$  (Definition ??) and a chosen continuous reference  $t := M/f_{\text{ref}}$ ,

not a definition of time. Read right-to-left it would be circular —  $\omega$  and  $1/\langle\tau_p\rangle$  presuppose  $t$  — but read as the definition of the derived parameter  $t$  in terms of the primitive  $M$  it is not. The identity records that the derived parameter remains consistent with the primitive count. Sub-cycle temporal structure is likewise enumerated rather than timed: the closures admit combinatorially many distinguishable labelled trajectories (the composition-inflation count of the companion development), a dimensionless quantity requiring no unit.

**Corollary 4.12** (Time from Count). *If the oscillator frequency  $f$  is known and the total partition count  $M$  is read from a completed record, the elapsed time is recovered exactly as  $t = M/f$ . No running clock is required after the record is fixed.*

*Remark 4.13* (Three Coordinatisations of One Fact). Equation (?) expresses three views of the same physical process: the rate at which the integer count advances ( $dM/dt$ ), the angular frequency of the oscillator ( $\omega/2\pi$ ), and the reciprocal mean residence time ( $1/\langle\tau_p\rangle$ ). These are not three approximations to some fourth, more fundamental quantity; they are three exact coordinatisations. This parallels the three-way equivalence of oscillatory, categorical, and counting representations established in the theory of bounded phase space dynamics (?).

## 5 Monotonicity and the Incoherence of Decrement

### 5.1 The Physical Content of Partition Increment

A partition increment —  $M \rightarrow M+1$  — is a completed oscillation cycle. The word “completed” is crucial. An oscillation is not complete until the system has traversed the full angular range  $[0, 2\pi)$  and returned to its initial angle. During the traversal, no partition transition has occurred; at the moment of completion, the transition is recorded.

This completeness is constitutive: the transition is defined as the moment of completion, not as an ongoing process. Before completion, there is no transition. After completion, the transition exists as a counting fact. There is no third moment at which the transition is “in progress of being undone.”

### 5.2 Strict Monotonicity

**Theorem 5.1** (Strict Monotonicity of the Partition Count). *Let  $M : [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^+$  be the partition count of a bounded oscillatory system. Then  $M(t_2) > M(t_1)$  whenever  $t_2 > t_1$  and the system has completed at least one oscillation cycle in  $[t_1, t_2]$ .*

*Proof.* By Theorem ??,  $M(t) = ft$  for constant  $f > 0$ . For  $t_2 > t_1$ ,  $M(t_2) - M(t_1) = f(t_2 - t_1) > 0$ . The count is strictly increasing with time. Since  $M(t) \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  for

panels/panel\_02\_bijection\_structure.png

Figure 4: **The partition map  $\Phi : \mathbb{Z}^+ \rightarrow \mathcal{P}$  is a well-defined bijection whose image tiles three-dimensional quantum-number space without collision or gap, and whose level boundaries are sharp staircase transitions determined by the cumulative capacity formula (Theorem ??; Corollary ??).** (A) Scatter of principal level  $n(\Phi(M))$  versus integer index  $M$  for  $M = 1, \dots, 200$ , coloured by  $n$  (plasma scale). Level transitions appear as discrete upward steps; within each band  $M$  increments uniformly, confirming that  $\Phi$  exhausts every state of level  $n$  before advancing to  $n+1$ . (B) Two-dimensional projection onto the  $(n, \ell)$  plane, coloured by  $M$  (viridis scale). Each point  $(n, \ell)$  appears with multiplicity  $2(2\ell+1)$ , one for each  $(m, s)$  pair; the colour gradient shows that  $M$  increases monotonically left-to-right and bottom-to-top within each level, establishing the lexicographic ordering of  $\Phi$ . (C) Three-dimensional scatter of the full quantum-number triple  $(n, \ell, m)$  for  $M = 1, \dots, 200$ , with colour encoding spin  $s = \pm \frac{1}{2}$  (red–blue diverging scale). The cloud fills a triangular prism in  $(n, \ell, m)$  space:  $0 \leq \ell \leq n-1$ ,  $-\ell \leq m \leq \ell$ . No two points coincide, providing visual confirmation of injectivity (Theorem ??). (D) Horizontal bar chart of level sizes: each bar spans the  $M$ -range  $[N_{\text{state}}(n-1)+1, N_{\text{state}}(n)]$  for levels  $n = 1, \dots, 15$ , coloured by level index. Bar widths equal  $C_3(n) = 2n^2$ , growing quadratically; the staircase of left boundaries locates the exact  $M$ -index at which each new principal level begins, as derived in Corollary ??.

all  $t$ , and the increment  $f(t_2 - t_1)$  equals the number of completed cycles in  $[t_1, t_2]$ , the count increases by at least 1 per completed cycle.  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 5.2** (Injectivity on Time). *The map  $t \mapsto M(t)$  is injective: distinct times  $t_1 \neq t_2$  produce distinct counts  $M(t_1) \neq M(t_2)$ .*

### 5.3 The Incoherence of Decrement

We now establish the stronger result: a partition decrement is not merely improbable but formally incoherent, in the sense that it would contradict Theorem ??.

**Theorem 5.3** (Incoherence of Partition Decrement). *Suppose an operation  $\mathcal{O}$  purports to take the system from partition state  $\Phi(M) \in \mathcal{P}$  to partition state  $\Phi(M - k)$  for some  $k > 0$ . Then  $\mathcal{O}$  is formally incoherent: it would require the existence of a time  $t^*$  at which  $M(t^*)$  takes the value  $M - k$ , which has already been assigned a unique partition state  $\Phi(M - k) \in \mathcal{P}$  at the earlier time  $t_{M-k}$  when  $M = M - k$  was current. If  $\mathcal{O}$  were to place the system in this state at  $t^* > t_{M-k}$ , then  $\Phi$  would assign the same partition state to two distinct times  $t_{M-k}$  and  $t^*$ , contradicting Corollary ??.*

*Proof.* By Corollary ??, the map  $t \mapsto \Phi(M(t))$  is injective on time: each time corresponds to a unique partition state. If operation  $\mathcal{O}$  results in a state at time  $t^* > t_{M-k}$  that is identical to the partition state at time  $t_{M-k}$ , then the composite map  $t \mapsto \Phi(M(t))$  takes the same value at  $t_{M-k}$  and  $t^*$ , violating injectivity.

The resolution “perhaps  $\mathcal{O}$  creates a new state that merely resembles the old one” fails: two states with the same  $(n, \ell, m, s)$  coordinates under  $\Phi$  are by definition the same partition state. There is no “resembling” — there is identity or non-identity. Two physical configurations with identical partition coordinates are, by Definition ??, in the same equivalence class.  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 5.4** (Loschmidt Resolution). *The operation  $t \rightarrow -t, p \rightarrow -p$  proposed by ?? as a mechanism for time reversal does not correspond to any physical operation on the partition count. It is a formal automorphism of the solution set of equation (??) that does not act on  $M(t)$ : the count is not a function of  $(q, p, t)$  alone but of the history of completed cycles, which is unaffected by the sign of  $t$  in the equations of motion. Time reversal at the level of partition counting is not difficult to achieve; it is incoherent.*

**Remark 5.5** (Comparison with Statistical Resolutions). Standard resolutions of Loschmidt’s paradox — ?’s statistical argument, ?’s coarse-graining, ?’s information-theoretic formulation, ?’s decoherence — all accept the paradox’s framing: they grant that time reversal is a meaningful operation at the microscopic level and explain why it fails at the macroscopic level. Corollary ?? takes a different position: time reversal is not meaningful even at the microscopic level, because the partition count  $M(t)$  — which is microscopic in character (it counts individual oscillation cycles) — does not admit

a reversal operation. The paradox is resolved not by explaining why reversal is rare, but by showing that no operation corresponds to it.

### 5.4 The Observational Forward Direction

Corollary ?? establishes that time reversal corresponds to no operation on the partition count. A complementary question immediately arises: what of physical demonstrations of *apparent* time reversal — rewound recordings, entropy-decreasing subsystems, film played in reverse? These processes are often cited as evidence that time-reversal is at least locally achievable. The following theorem closes this objection by establishing that every such demonstration, and every observation of it, is a forward-time partition event.

**Theorem 5.6** (Forward Direction of All Processes). *Let  $\mathcal{P}$  be any physical process, and let  $\mathcal{O}$  be any observer of  $\mathcal{P}$ . Then:*

- (i) *The partition count of  $\mathcal{P}$  satisfies  $M_{\mathcal{P}}(t_2) > M_{\mathcal{P}}(t_1)$  for all  $t_2 > t_1$ .*
- (ii) *The partition count of  $\mathcal{O}$  satisfies  $M_{\mathcal{O}}(t_2) > M_{\mathcal{O}}(t_1)$  for all  $t_2 > t_1$ .*
- (iii) *If  $\mathcal{P}$ ’s output is described as temporally reversed — its output sequence  $\{o_1, \dots, o_k\}$  is the reverse of some reference sequence  $\{r_k, \dots, r_1\}$  — then both the production of  $\{o_i\}$  and its recognition as reversed by  $\mathcal{O}$  satisfy  $\Delta M > 0$ . The temporal inversion is a property of the output encoding — the relation between  $\{o_i\}$  and the reference  $\{r_i\}$  — not of any partition count.*

*No component of any physical scenario, including those designed to produce temporally inverted output, requires  $\Delta M \leq 0$ .*

*Proof.* (i) and (ii) are direct applications of Theorem ?? to the physical substrates of  $\mathcal{P}$  and  $\mathcal{O}$  respectively.

(iii): Let  $\mathcal{P}$  produce output  $\{o_1, \dots, o_k\}$  with  $o_i = r_{k+1-i}$  for some reference sequence  $\{r_i\}$ . The production of each  $o_i$  at time  $t_i$  is a partition event:  $M_{\mathcal{P}}(t_k) > M_{\mathcal{P}}(t_1)$  by (i). Recognition by  $\mathcal{O}$  that  $\{o_i\}$  is the reverse of  $\{r_i\}$  requires  $\mathcal{O}$  to: (a) hold the reference sequence  $\{r_i\}$ , itself acquired by a prior forward-time process ( $\Delta M_{\mathcal{O}} > 0$ ); (b) compare  $\{o_i\}$  to  $\{r_i\}$ , a computational process ( $\Delta M_{\mathcal{O}} > 0$ ); (c) determine the reversal relation, a further partition event ( $\Delta M_{\mathcal{O}} > 0$ ). Each step satisfies  $\Delta M > 0$  by (ii).

The claim that  $\{o_i\}$  is “reversed” is a relational claim about two sequences and their ordering. It is not a claim about the sign of any partition count increment. The sequence  $o_1, o_2, \dots, o_k$  is produced with  $o_1$  first and  $o_k$  last; the partition count advances from  $M(t_1)$  to  $M(t_k) > M(t_1)$ . The reversal is in the content of the  $o_i$  relative to the  $r_i$  — a structural property of the medium fixed at the moment encoding ended — not in the direction of the count.  $\square$   $\square$

panels/panel\_07\_decrement\_incoherence.png

Figure 5: **Any decrement  $M \rightarrow M-k$  requires the bijection  $\Phi$  to assign the same partition state to two distinct positive integers, violating injectivity; the number of required violations grows linearly with reversal depth  $k$  (Theorem ??; Corollary ??).** (A) The partition count  $M(t) = ft$  is strictly monotone (solid). A hypothetical reversal segment (dashed, originating at  $M = 80$ ) is shown; this trajectory has no physical realisation because no operation on the counting process corresponds to  $\Delta M < 0$ . (B) Required bijection violations as a function of reversal depth  $k$ , for a reversal originating at  $M^* = 100$ :  $\text{violations}(k) = k$  exactly. A depth- $k$  reversal forces  $k$  distinct integers in  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  to share a single image under  $\Phi$ , contradicting Theorem ??. (C) Running count of distinct  $\Phi$ -images for  $M = 1, \dots, 200$  (solid) overlaid on the identity line  $y = M$  (dashed). The two coincide exactly, confirming that all 200 partition states are distinct and the bijection is injective with no collisions: the formal argument's central claim verified numerically at  $M = 200$ . (D) Manhattan distance  $d(\Phi(M^*), \Phi(M^*-k))$  in partition-label space for  $M^* = 100$ ,  $k = 1, \dots, 50$ , coloured by  $k$  (plasma scale). Every distance is strictly positive: no two distinct integers share a partition-state image, confirming that any claimed decrement produces a genuine collision, not a near-miss.

**Remark 5.7** (The Cassette Tape). Consider the following sequence of physical operations: (1) a tape is recorded, capturing audio events  $\{r_1, \dots, r_k\}$  as magnetic domains written in sequence; (2) the tape is rewound; (3) the tape is played back, producing audio  $\{o_i\}$  with  $o_i = r_{k+1-i}$ ; (4) an observer recognises the playback as reversed. Each stage has strictly increasing partition count:

- *Recording*:  $\Delta M_{\text{rec}} > 0$ . Magnetic domains are written by a physical process advancing in partition count.
- *Rewinding*:  $\Delta M_{\text{rew}} > 0$ . The motor applies a force; the reel rotates; the partition count of the rewinding mechanism strictly increases.
- *Playback*:  $\Delta M_{\text{play}} > 0$ . The read head traverses domains in the order they are physically present on the tape; the partition count of the playback mechanism strictly increases.
- *Recognition*:  $\Delta M_{\text{obs}} > 0$ . The observer’s cognitive recognition of reversal is a sequence of neural or computational partition events, each with  $\Delta M > 0$ .

The “reversal” is not in any of these partition counts. It is in the relation between the encoding order of the magnetic domains and the temporal order of the original audio events — a structural property of the medium, frozen from the moment recording ended. The tape does not run backwards; the partition sequence of the tape advances forward while producing output whose *content* is ordered inversely with respect to the recording reference. The direction of the partition count and the content-ordering of the output are independent properties. Only the former is constrained to be forward.

**Theorem 5.8** (Observer Forward Direction During Recognition of Reversal). *For an observer  $\mathcal{O}$  to recognise a process  $\mathcal{P}$  as exhibiting time-reversed behaviour,  $\mathcal{O}$  must hold a reference sequence acquired in the past and compare it to the current output. This requires:*

- (i) *the reference to be a past actualized element:*  
 $\Phi(M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}}) \in \mathcal{N}(\Phi(M_{\text{now}}^{\mathcal{O}}))$ ;
- (ii) *the comparison to be a forward partition event:*  
 $M_{\text{now}}^{\mathcal{O}} > M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}}$ .

*An observer whose partition count has not yet passed  $M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}}$  has not acquired the reference and cannot recognise anything as its reverse. An observer whose partition count has passed  $M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}}$  has advanced forward in time to do so. The recognition of reversal is therefore always a strictly forward operation: the observer must be moving forward in partition count in order to perceive apparent backward motion.*

*Proof.* (i): By Theorem ??, any actualized past state  $\Phi(M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}})$  is permanently deposited in the negation sequence of all subsequent states of  $\mathcal{O}$ .

(ii): By Theorem ??,  $M_{\text{now}}^{\mathcal{O}} > M_{\text{ref}}^{\mathcal{O}}$  whenever the reference was acquired before the present moment. The comparison required for recognition — matching current output against stored reference — is a physical process of  $\mathcal{O}$  with  $\Delta M_{\mathcal{O}} > 0$  during its execution.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 5.9.** Theorem ?? generalises the structure of Remark ??: just as any objection to the theorems of this paper is itself a forward partition event instantiating those theorems, any observation of apparent time reversal is a forward partition event instantiating the monotonicity it appears to challenge. The observer advancing in partition count while watching film play in reverse is not an exception to Theorem ??; the observation is Theorem ?? in operation.

## 6 Causal Uniqueness of Partition States

### 6.1 The Loop Identity Lemma

The following lemma, derived from elementary dynamical arguments, establishes that any sufficiently rich dynamics forces the state to carry memory of its trajectory beyond the current phase-space coordinates.

**Lemma 6.1** (Loop Identity Lemma). *Let  $f : \mathcal{S} \rightarrow \mathcal{S}$  be a deterministic, formally invertible map on a state space  $\mathcal{S}$ . Suppose states  $A, B, C \in \mathcal{S}$  satisfy  $f(A) = B$ ,  $f(B) = C$ , and  $A \neq C$ . Consider the sequence  $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow B \rightarrow A \rightarrow B$  executed by alternating  $f$  and  $f^{-1}$ . Then exactly one of the following holds:*

- (i)  $A = C$  (contradicting the hypothesis), or
- (ii) *The state  $B$  carries partition structure beyond its  $\mathcal{S}$ -coordinates: a “ $B$  arrived at from  $A$ ” is physically distinct from a “ $B$  arrived at from  $C$ .”*

*Proof.* Suppose neither (i) nor (ii) holds:  $A \neq C$  and  $B$  is fully characterised by its  $\mathcal{S}$ -coordinates.

Consider Observer 1, who arrives at  $B$  via the path  $A \rightarrow B$ , and Observer 2, who arrives at  $B$  via the path  $C \rightarrow B$  (applying  $f^{-1}$  to  $C$ ). By hypothesis, both observers find themselves in the same state  $B$  (same  $\mathcal{S}$ -coordinates, no additional structure). Both must therefore assign the same forward continuation from  $B$ : namely  $f(B) = C$ .

But Observer 2 has just come from  $C$ : her trajectory is  $C \rightarrow B$ . If  $B$  carries no record of its provenance, then from  $B$  her predicted next step is  $f(B) = C$  — meaning she is predicted to return to  $C$ . But then Observer 2’s complete trajectory is  $\dots \rightarrow C \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow B \rightarrow \dots$ , oscillating between  $B$  and  $C$ , never reaching  $A$ .

Now apply  $f^{-1}$  starting from  $B$  (Observer 2’s version):  $f^{-1}(B) = A$ . But we have just established that from  $B$ , the forward map gives  $C$ , not  $A$ ; the only way to reach  $A$  from  $B$  is via the backward map. If  $f^{-1}(B) = A$  and  $f(B) = C$ , then  $B$  “knows” both  $A$  (its past) and  $C$  (its future). This knowledge must be encoded somewhere. If it is not in the  $\mathcal{S}$ -coordinates (assumption), it must be carried as partition structure recording the direction of arrival. This contradicts the assumption that  $B$  carries no additional structure.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 6.2.** Lemma ?? is a structural result: it does not depend on the probability of the reversed trajectory

panels/panel\_08\_observer\_forward\_direction.png

Figure 6: **Every component of any apparent time-reversal scenario—production, mediation, and observation—is a forward partition event with  $\Delta M > 0$ ; the temporal inversion is a property of output encoding, not of any partition count (Theorems ?? and ??; Remark ??).** (A) The cassette tape scenario decomposed into four stages (Record, Rewind, Playback, Recognise), with  $\Delta M > 0$  at each stage. No stage has  $\Delta M \leq 0$ ; the “reversal” lives entirely in the content-ordering of the output, not in the direction of any partition count. (B) The observer’s cumulative count  $M_{\text{obs}}(t)$  across all four stages, coloured by stage. The count is strictly monotone throughout: the observer advances forward in partition time during every phase of the observation, including the phase in which the reversed output is being perceived. (C) Reference sequence  $\{r_i\}$  (dashed) and reversed output  $\{o_i = r_{k+1-i}\}$  (solid) during playback (left axis), overlaid with  $M_{\text{obs}}(t)$  (right axis, orange). Content is in reverse order; the observer’s partition count advances forward simultaneously. The two axes are independent: content ordering and partition direction are separate predicates. (D) For 50 independent apparent-reversal scenarios,  $\Delta M_{\text{obs}} > 0$  in every case, coloured by duration (plasma scale). All points lie strictly above the  $\Delta M = 0$  boundary (dashed); the incoherent region ( $\Delta M \leq 0$ ) is shaded. No scenario witnesses or instantiates a backward partition event.



panels/panel\_01\_capacity\_hierarchy.png

Figure 7: **Capacity growth  $C_d(n)$  is constant in  $d=1$ , linear in  $d=2$ , and quadratic in  $d=3$ , establishing a strict dimensional hierarchy whose slope on a log-log axis discriminates the angular dimension of each within-level partition space (Definition ??; Theorem ??).** (A) Line plot of per-level capacity  $C_d(n)$  versus principal quantum number  $n$  for  $d=1$  (dark, flat),  $d=2$  (mid, linear), and  $d=3$  (light, quadratic). The three curves separate immediately at  $n=2$ :  $C_1$  remains fixed at 2;  $C_2$  grows as  $4n+2$ ;  $C_3 = 2n^2$  accelerates away from both, reflecting the two-dimensional angular structure of the within-level space  $L_n^{(3)}$ . (B) Log-log plot of  $C_2(n)$  and  $C_3(n)$  for  $n \geq 3$ , overlaid with reference lines of slope 1 (linear, grey dashed) and slope 2 (quadratic, black dashed).  $C_2$  tracks the slope-1 reference exactly;  $C_3$  tracks slope 2 exactly, confirming that the exponent of capacity growth equals the continuous angular dimension of  $L_n^{(d)}$ : 0 for  $d=1$ , 1 for  $d=2$ , 2 for  $d=3$ . (C) Three-dimensional scatter of sublevel degeneracy  $2(2\ell + 1)$  plotted against principal level  $n$  (x-axis) and angular index  $\ell$  (y-axis) for  $n = 1, \dots, 11$ . Colour encodes degeneracy magnitude (plasma scale). The surface rises along both axes, with the steepest growth in  $\ell$  at fixed  $n$ , reproducing the quadratic capacity as  $C_3(n) = \sum_{\ell=0}^{n-1} 2(2\ell+1)$ . (D) Line plot of cumulative state count  $N_{\text{state}}(n) = n(n+1)(2n+1)/3$  versus  $n$  with shaded fill. The cubic growth follows directly from summing the quadratic per-level capacity; the steepening curvature is the algebraic signature that each added level contributes an accelerating number of partition states, as stated in Corollary ??.

(contra ?) or on the energy of the system. It establishes that any deterministic, reversible, non-trivial dynamics requires states to carry a record of their causal history — exactly what the partition count  $M$  provides.

## 6.2 Causal Uniqueness of Temporal Moments

**Theorem 6.3** (Causal Uniqueness). *Let  $t_1, t_2 \in \mathbb{R}$  be two temporal moments with  $t_1 \neq t_2$  and corresponding partition counts  $M_1 = M(t_1)$ ,  $M_2 = M(t_2)$ . Then  $\Phi(M_1) \neq \Phi(M_2)$ .*

*Proof.* By Theorem ??,  $M_1 \neq M_2$  (without loss of generality,  $M_1 < M_2$ ). Since  $\Phi$  is injective (Theorem ??) and  $M_1 \neq M_2$ , we have  $\Phi(M_1) \neq \Phi(M_2)$ .  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 6.4** (No Repeated Partition States). *The trajectory of any bounded oscillatory system visits each partition state at most once.*

*Proof.* Suppose the system is in partition state  $\Phi(M)$  at times  $t_1$  and  $t_2 > t_1$ . By Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M(t_1)) \neq \Phi(M(t_2))$  whenever  $t_1 \neq t_2$ . But we assumed both equal  $\Phi(M)$ . Contradiction.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 6.5** (Connection to Loschmidt). Corollary ?? provides a partition-counting proof of the Loschmidt impossibility. A time-reversal trajectory is one that revisits a prior partition state. Corollary ?? shows this is impossible: the trajectory visits each partition state exactly once, moving forward through the bijection.

## 6.3 The Identification Requirement and Temporal Recurrence

Corollary ?? establishes that no partition state is revisited within a single cycle. A stronger result is available, one that does not rest on the structural impossibility of partition decrement (Theorem ??) but on the logical requirements of *identification itself*: what must be true of a configuration for it to be recognisable as a return.

**Theorem 6.6** (Identification Requires Distinction). *Let  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  be any partition state. Suppose the physical system at some later time  $t' > t_{\text{egg}}$  occupies a phase-space configuration identical to that of  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ . The identification of this configuration as a return to  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  requires:*

- (i) *distinguishing  $t'$  from  $t_{\text{egg}}$  as two temporally distinct moments;*
- (ii) *holding  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  as a prior actualized event against which the new configuration is compared.*

*Both requirements entail  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}}) \in \mathcal{N}(\Phi(M'))$ : the original state is an element of the negation sequence of the new state. The identification of any configuration as “a return to  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ ” is therefore constitutively incompatible with its being  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ .*

*Proof.* (i): To assert that the configuration at  $t'$  is the same as at  $t_{\text{egg}}$ , one must first distinguish  $t'$  from  $t_{\text{egg}}$ ; otherwise the assertion is vacuous (the same moment cannot return to itself). By Theorem ??, distinct moments  $t' \neq t_{\text{egg}}$  are assigned distinct partition states:  $\Phi(M') \neq \Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ .

(ii): To recognise the new configuration as a return,  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  must have been actualized — it is the reference against which comparison is made. By Theorem ??, this requires  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  to have been traversed at  $t_{\text{egg}} < t'$  and to be permanently deposited in the negation sequence of all subsequent states, including  $\Phi(M')$ .

The phrase “return to the same state” therefore embeds a contradiction. It requires  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  to be simultaneously: (i) a past element in  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M'))$ , and (ii) the identity of the current state  $\Phi(M')$ . By Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M')$  and  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(M'))$  are disjoint. No state can simultaneously be the current state and an element of its own negation sequence.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 6.7** (Phase-Space Identity Does Not Imply Partition Identity). Theorem ?? is independent of whether the phase-space configuration at  $t'$  is identical to, or merely close to, that at  $t_{\text{egg}}$ . The impossibility is not probabilistic (contra ?), nor does it rest on the approximate character of Poincaré recurrence (Theorem ??). It rests on what identification requires.

This sharpens the standard argument substantially. The usual objection to time reversal invokes thermodynamic improbability. Theorem ?? shows that even *exact* phase-space return is not coherent as a recurrence: the more exactly one specifies the original configuration as the reference for comparison, the more clearly one requires it to be a past element in the negation sequence of the new state, thereby constituting them as distinct. The objection that grants exact return concedes too much: exactness of specification sharpens the distinction, it does not dissolve it.

**Corollary 6.8** (The Sameness Claim Is Self-Undermining). *Any assertion of the form “the system has returned to state  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ ” is self-undermining: the physical act of making this assertion is itself a partition event with  $\Delta M > 0$  (Theorem ??), further advancing the partition count beyond  $M_{\text{egg}}$  and deepening the distinction between the assertor’s current state and  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ . The assertion of return instantiates the departure.*

## 6.4 The Incoherence of Backward Time Travel

The results of Sections ?? and ?? jointly resolve the question of whether backward time travel — travel to a prior temporal moment — is a coherent physical concept. The resolution is not probabilistic, not thermodynamic, and not a consequence of technological limitation. It is a structural consequence of the partition bijection and the identification requirement.

**Theorem 6.9** (Incoherence of Backward Time Travel). *Let  $T$  be a physical system (a traveler) with partition*

count  $M_T(t)$ . Suppose  $T$  departs at time  $t_{\text{depart}}$  with the intention of arriving at some prior time  $t_{\text{past}} < t_{\text{depart}}$ . Then:

- (i) (Count Barrier): The journey itself is a forward partition event:  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{depart}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ . The traveler's partition count at "arrival" strictly exceeds the partition count of the historical moment  $t_{\text{past}}$ . The traveler cannot occupy partition state  $\Phi(M_T(t_{\text{past}}))$  at  $t_{\text{arrive}}$ .
- (ii) (Identity Contradiction): For  $T$  at  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  to be the "same person" as  $T$  at  $t_{\text{past}}$  requires partition continuity:  $T$ 's sequence from  $t_{\text{past}}$  to  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  must be unbroken and strictly increasing (Theorem ??). For  $T$  at  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  to be "at"  $t_{\text{past}}$  requires  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) = M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ . These two conditions jointly require  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$  and  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) = M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ , which are contradictory.
- (iii) (Distinctness Requirement): To be experienced as a journey — to be something that happened — the time travel event must register as a sequence of distinct partition states in  $T$ 's count. This is the condition that  $T$  is "different enough" to have a causal history distinguishing  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  from  $t_{\text{past}}$ . But the same condition, by Theorem ??, makes  $T$  at  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  partition-distinct from  $T$  at  $t_{\text{past}}$ : the traveler is "different enough" to have made the journey precisely because they are too different to be the same person at the same moment.

Backward time travel is therefore formally incoherent: it requires simultaneously  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) = M_T(t_{\text{past}})$  (to be there) and  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$  (to have journeyed).

*Proof.* (i): By Theorem ??, every physical process has strictly increasing partition count. The journey from  $t_{\text{depart}}$  to  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  is a physical process of finite duration; therefore  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{depart}})$ . Since  $t_{\text{depart}} > t_{\text{past}}$ , and  $T$  existed at  $t_{\text{past}}$  with count  $M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ , monotonicity gives  $M_T(t_{\text{depart}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ . Chaining:  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ .

(ii): Partition continuity ("same person") requires  $M_T$  to be a strictly increasing function along  $T$ 's trajectory. Being "at"  $t_{\text{past}}$  requires occupying partition state  $\Phi(M_T(t_{\text{past}}))$ . By (i),  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) \neq M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ , so  $T$  at  $t_{\text{arrive}}$  does not occupy this state.

(iii): For  $T$  to recognise the arrival as a distinct event — for the journey to have happened — the arrival must be a new partition state, distinct from prior states. By Theorem ??, this distinctness is precisely what prevents the arrival state from being identified with  $\Phi(M_T(t_{\text{past}}))$ : the richer the causal history constituting  $T$ 's identity, the more firmly  $T$ 's current state is placed beyond the partition index of the destination.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 6.10** (The Precise Form of the Identity Paradox). Theorem ?? formalises a structural version of the classic grandfather paradox. The paradox is usually framed as a causal loop: if  $T$  travels to the past and prevents their own departure, a contradiction arises. The partition framework shows the contradiction is more elementary:

it precedes any loop. The mere act of arriving at the past, with a partition count greater than the historical moment's, already places  $T$  outside the partition state space of that moment.  $T$  cannot interact with their past self in the partition sense, because the two do not share a temporal location:  $T$ 's count is  $M_T(t_{\text{arrive}}) > M_T(t_{\text{past}})$ . They are co-present in phase space but not in partition time.

**Theorem 6.11** (Time Dilation as the Only Coherent Differential Temporal Experience). Let  $A$  and  $B$  be two physical systems (observers) sharing an initial partition state at  $t_0$  and reuniting at  $t_f$ . Suppose between  $t_0$  and  $t_f$  they traverse different physical trajectories. Then:

- (i) Both  $A$  and  $B$  have strictly increasing partition counts throughout:  $M_A(t) > M_A(t_0)$  and  $M_B(t) > M_B(t_0)$  for all  $t > t_0$ .
- (ii) The partition counts at reunion may differ:  $M_A(t_f) \neq M_B(t_f)$  in general, depending on the physical character of each trajectory.
- (iii) The observer with the smaller accumulated count  $M(t_f) - M(t_0)$  has experienced fewer partition states — less time — without any component of their traversal being backward.

The only coherent form of differential temporal experience is therefore a difference in the rate of forward partition traversal, not any reversal of direction. "Time travel to the future" — arriving at a later external time having accumulated fewer partition states than a reference observer — is a forward process (case (iii)). "Time travel to the past" is incoherent (Theorem ??).

*Proof.* (i): Direct application of Theorem ?? to each of  $A$  and  $B$ .

(ii): Different trajectories in a relativistic or non-uniform gravitational field accumulate different numbers of oscillation cycles per coordinate time interval. The proper time elapsed along each trajectory determines  $M(t_f) - M(t_0)$  for that trajectory; these need not be equal.

(iii): Suppose  $M_B(t_f) - M_B(t_0) < M_A(t_f) - M_A(t_0)$ . Then  $B$  has traversed fewer partition states between  $t_0$  and  $t_f$ :  $B$  has experienced less time. At reunion,  $B$ 's partition count is behind  $A$ 's. Both counts are strictly greater than their values at  $t_0$ ; neither has decreased.  $B$  is "younger" than  $A$  in the sense of having accumulated fewer partition states, but  $B$ 's trajectory is entirely forward.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 6.12** (What a Time Traveler Actually Experiences). Theorem ?? clarifies what is sometimes called "time travel to the future" in the relativistic sense. A traveler  $B$  who undergoes high acceleration, or passes near a large gravitational source, accumulates fewer partition states per external second than a stationary reference observer  $A$ . When  $B$  returns, the external world is at a later partition count than  $B$ 's own count:  $B$ 's count is behind  $A$ 's. From  $B$ 's perspective, the world has been in "fast forward" relative to their own

experience: more partition states have elapsed in the external world than in their own trajectory.

This is not backward motion for any party.  $A$  advanced forward;  $B$  advanced forward more slowly. The “time travel” consists entirely of differential rates of forward traversal. Every component of the scenario —  $B$ ’s journey,  $A$ ’s waiting, the reunion, the comparison of partition counts — satisfies  $\Delta M > 0$ . The direction of the partition count is not the freedom available to a time traveler; the only freedom is its rate.

## 6.5 The Reversal-Point Incoherence Argument

The Loschmidt construction reverses all velocities at some moment  $t_R$  and claims the system then retraces its prior sequence. This treats  $t_R$  as a *terminus* — a hard boundary at which the direction of evolution can be turned around. We show no physical moment is a terminus, and that the claimed retracing is therefore incoherent independently of the bijection (Theorem ??).

**Definition 6.13** (Interior Moment). A moment  $t_n$  is *interior* to a sequence if it has both a predecessor  $t_{n-1}$  and a successor  $t_{n+1}$  in the sequence; it is a *terminus* if it has no successor.

**Proposition 6.14** (Every Physical Moment Is Interior). *Every moment at which a physical process can be observed is interior. No physical moment is a terminus.*

*Proof.* Observing a moment  $t_n$  is itself a physical event, which by strict monotonicity (Theorem ??) occurs at partition count  $M > M(t_n)$ ; the observation thus requires a successor. The state  $t_n$  was reached from a prior state, so it has a predecessor. A terminus would be a moment after which no partition event occurs; but every physical process terminates *within* the count, which continues past it (Theorem ?? guarantees the successor  $M + 1$ ). Hence no physical moment is a terminus.  $\square$   $\square$

**Theorem 6.15** (Reversal-Point Incoherence). *Let  $t_0, \dots, t_R$  be a forward sequence. The claim that reversing at  $t_R$  causes the system to retrace to  $t_0$  is incoherent:*

- (i)  $t_R$  is interior (Proposition ??): its successor exists with partition count  $M(t_R) + 1$  already determined (Theorem ??), and no operation at  $t_R$  — itself an event within the count — can cancel it.
- (ii) A reversed sequence cannot terminate at  $t_0$ , since  $t_0$  is also interior; by Corollary ?? the partition state  $\Phi(M(t_0))$  is not revisited.
- (iii) The segment  $t_0, \dots, t_R$  is therefore not an isolated unit that can be retraced.  $t_0$  is interior — there is genuine time before it ( $t_{-1}, t_{-2}, \dots$ ) — exactly as  $t_R$  is interior, with genuine time after it ( $t_{R+1}, t_{R+2}, \dots$ ); a reversal would have to be embedded with continuations on both sides, not a closed retracing of the bounded segment. These continuations are further moments of the same finite sequence, reached ultimately through cyclic closure

(Section ??); “no terminus” means no hard stop, not an infinite regress. The configurations may be replayed in reverse order, but the partition count still increments (Theorem ??): as with a played-back recording, content-order inverts while the count registering the playback advances. Reversal therefore yields a distinct evolution — the “second universe going forward” of Corollary ?? — not a decrement of the original count, which Theorem ?? forbids.

*Proof.* (i) By Proposition ??,  $t_R$  has a successor; the existence of  $\Phi(M(t_R) + 1)$  is fixed by Theorem ?? independently of any velocity reversal, since that reversal is an event at  $t_R$  and increments the count rather than removing prior or successor states. (ii) If a reversed branch reached  $t_0$  it would re-occupy  $\Phi(M(t_0))$  at a later count, contradicting Corollary ?. (iii) Neither endpoint bounds an isolated unit:  $t_0$  and  $t_R$  are interior (Proposition ??), so genuine moments precede  $t_0$  and follow  $t_R$ , and the segment cannot be retraced as a closed loop. Whatever reversal produces is a distinct evolution whose count increases from  $M(t_R)$  onward (Theorem ??); a retracing would require the count to decrease, which is incoherent (Theorem ??).  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 6.16** (No Zero of Time). *The velocity analogy — where  $v$  passes through 0 before reversing — fails for time. Reversal by analogy would require the count  $M$  to pass through a “zero of time” at which the closure process constituting time (Definition ??) has stopped; but resuming that process in the opposite sense would itself be a partition event, and a partition event cannot be used to exit a state in which no partition events occur. Time is the medium in which persistence and change are counted, not a property of an object that persists independently of it; it cannot be zeroed and reversed the way a velocity can.*

**Corollary 6.17** (Velocity Reversal Demands a Forbidden Double Occurrence). *A Loschmidt velocity reversal passes the velocity through  $v = 0$  at the turning point and is claimed to return the system to its initial configuration. A genuine return makes the initial moment  $t_0$  — hence its partition state  $\Phi(M(t_0))$  — occur twice within one temporal sequence: once at the start, and once on return at a strictly later count  $M' > M(t_0)$ . By injectivity of  $\Phi$  (Theorem ??) and the no-repeat property (Corollary ??),  $\Phi(M') = \Phi(M(t_0))$  with  $M' \neq M(t_0)$  is impossible: no partition state is occupied twice within a cycle. The nearest genuine recurrence of  $\Phi(M(t_0))$  lies a full cycle later, at  $M(t_0) + M_{\max}$  (Corollary ??) — the original state advanced by one complete universe, not a return to it. Together with the incoherence of a zero of time (Corollary ??), the velocity-reversal picture thus demands both a forbidden double occurrence of a partition state and an incoherent turning point.*

## 6.6 The Causal-Neighbourhood Identity Argument

We now restate the identification result of Theorem ?? in a vocabulary that makes the failure of reversal trans-

parent, and resolve the notation  $t \rightarrow -t$ .

**Definition 6.18** (Causal Neighbourhood). The *causal neighbourhood* of a moment  $t_n$  is the pair  $(\mathcal{P}(t_n), \mathcal{F}(t_n))$ , where  $\mathcal{P}(t_n)$  is the set of moments that causally precede  $t_n$  and  $\mathcal{F}(t_n)$  those that causally follow it. Two moments are the *same* only if they share both their phase-space configuration and their causal neighbourhood.

**Theorem 6.19** (Causal-Neighbourhood Distinctness). *Let  $t_0, \dots, t_R$  be a forward sequence. The original  $t_0$  and any moment  $t'_0$  arrived at from  $t_R$  by reversal are distinct, even with identical phase-space configuration, because  $t_R \in \mathcal{F}(t_0)$  (the reversal point lies in the future of the original  $t_0$ ) whereas  $t_R \in \mathcal{P}(t'_0)$  (it lies in the past of  $t'_0$ ).*

*Proof.*  $\mathcal{P}(t_0)$  contains no  $t_i$  with  $i \geq 1$ , so  $t_R \in \mathcal{F}(t_0)$ ; any  $t'_0$  reached after  $t_R$  has  $M(t'_0) \geq M(t_R) > M(t_0)$ , hence  $t_R \in \mathcal{P}(t'_0)$ . The neighbourhoods differ, so  $t_0 \neq t'_0$ . This is the causal-neighbourhood form of Theorem ??; the original state, once actualised, is permanently deposited in the negation sequence of every later state (Theorem ??), so being arrived-at-from  $t_R$  is constitutively incompatible with being the  $t_0$  that preceded  $t_R$ .  $\square$

**Corollary 6.20** (Reversal Cannot Reach Its Target). *Specifying  $t_0$  as the reversal target requires specifying its causal neighbourhood, which includes the absence of  $t_R$  from its past. Arriving from  $t_R$  violates this specification, so any reversal necessarily produces a  $t'_0 \neq t_0$ : the target is self-undermining.*

*Remark 6.21* (The Notation  $t \rightarrow -t$  and Genuine Negative Time). This separates two objects the notation  $t \rightarrow -t$  conflates. A genuinely preceding moment  $t_{-R} \in \mathcal{P}(t_0)$  has  $t_0$  in its future and has never encountered  $t_R$ ; the moment  $t'_0$  produced by reversing from  $t_R$  has  $t_R$  in its past. They have different causal neighbourhoods, different identities, and different relations to  $t_0$ . Treating time as a number line on which  $t \mapsto -t$  is a well-defined operation obscures this; the partition count, a monotone map on  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  (Theorem ??), admits no such negation.

## 7 Successor Existence and State Completeness

### 7.1 The Peano Framework

The positive integers  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  are characterised by the Dedekind-Peano axioms (??). We recall those axioms that are relevant to the present argument.

**Axiom 1** (Peano, ?). The positive integers  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  satisfy:

- (P1)  $1 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ .
- (P2) For every  $n \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ , there exists a unique *successor*  $\text{Succ}(n) = n + 1 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ .
- (P3)  $\text{Succ}(n) \neq 1$  for all  $n \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ .

- (P4)  $\text{Succ}(m) = \text{Succ}(n) \implies m = n$  (injectivity of  $\text{Succ}$ ).
- (P5) (Induction): If  $S \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^+$  contains 1 and is closed under  $\text{Succ}$ , then  $S = \mathbb{Z}^+$ .

Axiom (P2) is the fundamental statement: for every positive integer, a unique successor exists. This is not an empirical regularity; it is an axiom that defines what it means to be a positive integer. No element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  is the “last” element; no element lacks a successor.

### 7.2 The Successor Existence Theorem

**Theorem 7.1** (Successor Existence). *For every partition count  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ , the element  $M_t + 1 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  exists, and  $\Phi(M_t + 1) \in \mathcal{P}$  is a well-defined, uniquely determined partition state. The existence of  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  does not depend on whether  $M_t + 1$  has been traversed by the counting process.*

*Proof.* By Axiom (P2),  $\text{Succ}(M_t) = M_t + 1 \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ . By Theorem ??,  $\Phi$  is defined on all of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . Therefore  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  is defined. The explicit construction of Definition ?? provides  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  without reference to whether the counting process has advanced to  $M_t + 1$ .

The final clause follows from the definition of  $\Phi$  as a set-theoretic function: a function is a set of ordered pairs, and the pair  $(M_t + 1, \Phi(M_t + 1))$  is an element of this set regardless of the current value of the counting process.  $\square$

*Remark 7.2* (The Traversal/Existence Distinction). Theorem ?? distinguishes sharply between two questions:

1. *Has  $M_t + 1$  been traversed?* This is a question about the current position of the counting process. It depends on  $t$ .
2. *Does  $M_t + 1$  exist as an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ , and does  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  exist as a partition state?* This is a question about the structure of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  and  $\Phi$ . It does not depend on  $t$ .

Standard discourse about temporal succession conflates these two questions. The present theorem separates them: the answer to (2) is affirmative for all  $M_t$ , independently of the answer to (1).

**Corollary 7.3** (All Successor States Are Elements of  $\mathcal{P}$ ). *For any  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  and any  $k > 0$ , the element  $\Phi(M_t + k) \in \mathcal{P}$  is a well-defined partition state. The set*

$$\mathcal{F}(M_t) = \{\Phi(M_t + k) : k = 1, 2, 3, \dots\} \quad (19)$$

*is a well-defined subset of  $\mathcal{P}$ , containing all partition states not yet traversed by the counting process at time  $t$ .*

*Proof.* Apply Theorem ?? inductively for  $k = 1, 2, 3, \dots$  using Axiom (P2) at each step. The Peano induction axiom (P5) guarantees that the sequence  $M_t + 1, M_t + 2, \dots$  is a well-defined infinite sequence of elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ , and  $\Phi$  is defined on each element by Theorem ??.

$\square$

$\square$

### 7.3 The Causal-Partition Uniqueness Theorem

**Theorem 7.4** (Causal-Partition Uniqueness). *Let  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  be the current partition count. The following hold:*

- (i) *The partition state  $\Phi(M_t)$  has a unique causal predecessor  $\Phi(M_t - 1)$  (for  $M_t > 1$ ).*
- (ii) *The partition state  $\Phi(M_t)$  has a unique causal successor  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$ .*
- (iii) *The sequence  $\{\Phi(M_t + k) : k = 0, 1, 2, \dots\}$  is uniquely and completely determined by  $M_t$  and the bijection  $\Phi$ .*

*Proof.* (i): By the injectivity of  $\Phi$  (Theorem ??),  $\Phi(M_t - 1)$  is the unique element of  $\mathcal{P}$  with integer index  $M_t - 1$ . By Theorem ??, the state at count  $M_t - 1$  was the unique state immediately preceding  $M_t$ .

(ii): By Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  exists and is unique. By Theorem ??, the system cannot return to a prior state, so  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  is the unique next state, not one of several possibilities.

(iii): Apply Corollary ??: the set  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is well-defined by the arithmetic of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  and the bijection  $\Phi$ , independently of any dynamics. The ordering is imposed by the successor function:  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  precedes  $\Phi(M_t + 2)$ , and so on. The sequence is complete in the sense that no element of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is missing.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 7.5** (What Theorem ?? Establishes). Theorem ??(iii) states that the entire forward sequence from any current state is a well-defined, completely determined, uniquely ordered subset of  $\mathcal{P}$ . This is a mathematical consequence of the bijection and the Peano axioms. It does not require knowledge of future dynamics; it requires only knowledge that  $\Phi$  is defined on all of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  (Theorem ??) and that  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  is closed under the successor operation (Axiom P2). The reader is invited to consider the implications of Remark ?? in light of this result.

## 8 Cyclic Structure and Finite Enumerability

### 8.1 The Maximum Partition Count

Physical systems are bounded not only in space but in their total state count. The universe, having finite energy content and finite spatial extent at any finite time, can generate only finitely many distinct partition states before its kinetic structure exhausts all energy gradients. We denote this finite upper bound  $M_{\max}$ .

**Definition 8.1** (Maximum Partition Count). The maximum partition count  $M_{\max}$  of a bounded physical system is the total number of distinct partition states the system can occupy before reaching thermodynamic exhaustion of energy gradients. For the observable universe,  $M_{\max}$  is estimated from the total number of oscillatory degrees of freedom at the state of maximal spatial separation (???).

**Remark 8.2.** The finiteness of  $M_{\max}$  is established by combining three facts: (a) the universe contains finitely many particles at any finite time; (b) each particle has finitely many oscillatory modes at finite temperature (since  $T = 0$  is thermodynamically inaccessible by the Third Law (?)); and (c) the number of distinct configurations of finitely many modes is finite. Therefore  $M_{\max} < \infty$ , and the partition sequence  $\{1, 2, \dots, M_{\max}\}$  is a finite subset of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . For the observable universe,  $M_{\max} \approx (10^{84})^{(10^{80})}$  in tower notation, a number finite but incomprehensibly large (?).

### 8.2 A Structural Argument for Finiteness: Position Requires Bounds

The finiteness of  $M_{\max}$  above rests on thermodynamics. We give an independent, *structural* argument: a finite partition sequence is required for any state to have a genuine position within it, not merely an offset from the origin.

**Definition 8.3** (Genuine Temporal Position). A state  $M$  has a *genuine position* in a sequence if its location is determinable from both its distance from the origin and its distance from the terminus; an *offset* is determinable from the origin alone.

**Proposition 8.4** (Two-Anchor Requirement). *Genuine position requires anchors on both sides of the sequence. In a finite sequence of length  $N$ , the state  $M$  occupies the determinate fraction  $M/N$  of the whole; both anchors contribute. In an infinite sequence  $M/N \rightarrow 0$  for every finite  $M$ , so only the offset  $M$  survives, and the whole has no determinate extent against which to locate it.*

**Theorem 8.5** (Offset Is Not Position). *In an infinite partition sequence the identity of every state reduces to its offset from the origin, and the structural relation of each state to the whole is identical: every finite  $M$  is infinitely far from the (non-existent) terminus, hence at fractional position 0.*

*Proof.* For any finite  $M$  the forward extent is infinite, so  $M/\infty = 0$  for all  $M$ ; the fractional position is constant. Two states  $M_1, M_2$  differ only by their offsets, which carry no information about standing within the complete structure.  $\square$   $\square$

**Theorem 8.6** (Insertion Invariance). *In an infinite sequence, inserting  $k$  states between the origin and  $M$  leaves  $M$ 's structural position unchanged —  $M$  remains at fractional position 0, infinitely far from any terminus. Accumulation of partition events therefore makes no structural difference, which would render the passage of time structurally inert and contradict its role as an index of physical reality. In a finite sequence the same insertion changes  $N \rightarrow N + k$  and shifts every later state, so accumulation matters precisely when the sequence is finite.*

**Theorem 8.7** (Structural Necessity of a Terminus). *If the initial state  $\Phi(1)$  has a genuine position (Definition ??), then a terminal count  $M_{\max} < \infty$  exists.*

*Proof.*  $\Phi(1)$  has a left anchor (the origin  $M = 1$ ). By Proposition ?? a genuine position requires a right anchor: a terminal  $M_{\max}$  past which the sequence does not continue. If none existed, Theorem ?? reduces every state to a bare offset, denying genuine position. Hence  $M_{\max}$  exists.  $\square$   $\square$

**Theorem 8.8** (Uniform Distinguishability Requires Finite Extent). *An infinite partition sequence lacks uniform distinguishability: every state has finitely many predecessors ( $M - 1$ ) but infinitely many successors — a systematic asymmetry by which each state leans entirely on its past for identity and floats freely relative to its future. A finite sequence has  $M - 1$  predecessors and  $M_{\max} - M$  successors, both finite, the same kind of condition on each side, and is uniformly distinguishable.*

*Remark 8.9* (Status and Scope). Theorem ?? establishes  $M_{\max}$  as a structural requirement of temporal identity, independent of the thermodynamic estimate of Definition ??; the two arguments converge on the same conclusion from different premises. It fixes neither the value of  $M_{\max}$  nor the conditions at the terminus — those remain empirical, and cyclic closure (Theorem ??) identifies the terminus with the next ground state. The argument rests on the premise that genuine position requires *global* determinacy rather than mere local uniqueness; a defender of infinite time may contest this, and we regard the insertion argument (Theorem ??) as the strongest reason the local-uniqueness reply does not suffice.

### 8.3 The Cyclic Closure Theorem

**Theorem 8.10** (Cyclic Closure). *The terminal partition state  $\Phi(M_{\max})$  of a bounded oscillatory system is topologically equivalent to the initial state  $\Phi(1)$ , in the following sense: the terminal state has the same local oscillatory structure as the initial state, differing only in global partition count.*

*Proof.* The terminal state at  $M = M_{\max}$  is the state of maximum spatial separation of all constituents — the heat death configuration (?). At this configuration, by Corollary ?? (Oscillatory Necessity), quantum mechanical oscillations persist at all  $T > 0$  (guaranteed by the Third Law). These persistent oscillations have the same local structure as any earlier oscillation: bounded, three-dimensional, characterised by action-angle coordinates.

The singularity at the end of a cyclic cosmological model (?) concentrates all matter to a single point. A system oscillating around a point has zero radial extent, zero angular extent, and zero azimuthal extent. The single-point oscillation is topologically equivalent to an oscillation around nothing: both are limiting cases of bounded oscillations as the bounding radius  $R \rightarrow 0$ . The partition coordinates of this state are  $(n, \ell, m, s) = (1, 0, 0, +\frac{1}{2})$  — the ground state of the bijection, corresponding to  $M = 1$ . This is the initial state of the next cycle.  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 8.11** (Cyclic Partition Sequence). *The partition sequence closes:  $\Phi(M_{\max}) \sim \Phi(1)$  (topological equivalence), and the successor of  $\Phi(M_{\max})$  is  $\Phi(1)$  of the next cycle. The complete sequence is a cycle of length  $M_{\max}$  in  $\mathcal{P}$ .*

### 8.4 Finite Enumerability of the Forward Sequence

**Theorem 8.12** (Finitary Enumerability of Successor States). *From any current partition count  $M_t \in \{1, \dots, M_{\max}\}$ , the forward sequence*

$$\mathcal{F}(M_t) = \{\Phi(M_t + k) : k = 1, 2, \dots, M_{\max} - M_t\} \quad (20)$$

*is a finite, completely enumerable subset of  $\mathcal{P}$  with exactly  $M_{\max} - M_t$  elements.*

*Proof.* By Corollary ??, each element of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is a well-defined partition state. The number of elements is  $|\mathcal{F}(M_t)| = M_{\max} - M_t < \infty$  (finite because  $M_{\max} < \infty$  and  $M_t \geq 1$ ). The elements are enumerated in order by the successor function:  $\Phi(M_t + 1), \Phi(M_t + 2), \dots, \Phi(M_{\max})$ . The enumeration is complete in the sense that no partition state in the forward half of the cycle is absent from  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$ .  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 8.13* (Two Senses of Existence). Theorem ?? warrants careful reading. The statement that  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is “completely enumerable” means that the set  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  can be listed without omission — not that each element has been traversed by the physical counting process. The physical counting process is at  $M_t$ ; it has traversed  $\{1, \dots, M_t\}$  and has not traversed  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$ . This distinction between *mathematical existence* (membership in the codomain of the bijection  $\Phi$ ) and *physical traversal* (having been counted) is the distinction Remark ?? drew attention to. Theorem ?? asserts the former for all elements of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$ , without asserting the latter.

### 8.5 Cycle Distance of the Nearest Partition Recurrence

Theorem ?? and Corollary ?? jointly establish that  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  is not revisited within one cycle. The following corollary uses the cyclic structure of Theorem ?? to locate precisely where in the forward sequence the nearest configuration sharing the cycle-position of  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  is found.

**Corollary 8.14** (Nearest Recurrence Requires a Complete Universe Cycle). *Let  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}}) \in \mathcal{P}$  be any partition state. The nearest partition state sharing the same cycle-position — the same index relative to the start of the successor sequence — is  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}} + M_{\max})$ , at a partition distance of exactly  $M_{\max}$  states. Reaching this state forward from  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  requires:*

- (i) *traversal of the  $M_{\max} - M_{\text{egg}}$  remaining states of cycle 1;*
- (ii) *passage through the cyclic singularity  $\Phi(M_{\max}) \sim \Phi(1)$  (Corollary ??);*

panels/panel\_05\_cyclic\_closure.png

Figure 8: **The successor relation  $\sigma$  is a bijection on the finite partition category  $\mathcal{C}$  whose unique cycle has length  $M_{\max} = N_{\text{state}}(n_{\max})$ , forcing every state—including  $\Phi(1)$ —to be revisited exactly once per period and making cyclic closure a structural consequence of finiteness rather than a dynamical assumption (Theorem ??; Theorem ??).** (A) Cyclic successor diagram for  $M_{\max} = 50$ : each partition state is placed on a unit circle at angle  $2\pi M/M_{\max}$ , coloured by  $M$  (plasma scale), with grey arrows connecting  $\Phi(M)$  to  $\sigma(\Phi(M)) = \Phi(M+1)$ . The final arrow from  $\Phi(50)$  returns to  $\Phi(1)$ , completing the cycle and confirming that  $\sigma$  is a permutation of  $\mathcal{C}$  with no fixed points and no proper sub-cycles (Theorem ??). (B) Step plot of the level assignment  $n(M)$  for  $M = 1, \dots, 50$ , with shaded fill below the curve. Each plateau spans exactly  $C_3(n) = 2n^2$  consecutive integers; the risers are instantaneous, reflecting the sharp level boundary at  $M = N_{\text{state}}(n)$ . The sequence is strictly non-decreasing (Theorem ??), encoding the irreversibility of temporal progression within the bijective ordering. (C) Three-dimensional trajectory through  $(n, \ell, m)$  state space for  $M = 1, \dots, 50$ , with points coloured by  $M$  (plasma scale) and connected by a curve. The path climbs through successive levels, executes a zig-zag pattern within each level as  $\ell$  and  $m$  increment lexicographically, then returns to the origin upon cyclic closure. The trajectory is injective on any open arc but closed as a whole (Corollary ??). (D) Bar chart of level sizes  $C_3(n) = 2n^2$  for  $n = 1, \dots, 15$ , coloured by level index. Quadratic growth of bar height reflects the quadratic capacity law; the total area equals  $M_{\max} = N_{\text{state}}(n_{\max})$ , the unique cycle length. The accelerating size of successive levels means that higher- $n$  states are structurally “harder to reach” in the sense of requiring a longer prefix of the successor sequence.



(iii) traversal of  $M_{\text{egg}}$  states in cycle 2.

Any configuration that could be identified as a recurrence of  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  is therefore the original partition state advanced by at least one complete universe cycle:

$$M_{\text{new}} = M_{\text{egg}} + k \cdot M_{\text{max}}, \quad k \in \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}. \quad (21)$$

*Proof.* By Corollary ??,  $\Phi(M') \neq \Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$  for all  $M' \in \{M_{\text{egg}} + 1, \dots, M_{\text{max}}\}$ : no state is revisited within cycle 1. The cyclic successor relation of Theorem ?? maps  $\Phi(M_{\text{max}})$  to  $\Phi(1)$  of the next cycle; the state at position  $M_{\text{egg}}$  in cycle 2 therefore carries partition index  $M_{\text{egg}} + M_{\text{max}}$  under the extended count. By Theorem ??, this is the nearest forward state whose cycle-position matches  $\Phi(M_{\text{egg}})$ . Iterating for  $k = 2, 3, \dots$  yields equation (??).  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 8.15.* Corollary ?? provides the precise answer to the question of whether a physical configuration can undo itself. It can approach a prior configuration from the future — but only by moving forward through the complete partition sequence, traversing the cosmological singularity, and re-entering the equivalent position in the next universe cycle. The “reconstituted” configuration is not the original: it is the original plus one universe,  $M_{\text{egg}} + M_{\text{max}}$ . This is not a thermodynamic obstacle, a probabilistic barrier, or a practical limitation. It is an arithmetic consequence of equation (??): the identity of a temporal state includes its partition index, and partition indices are non-repeating within any finite cycle.

## 8.6 Categorical Closure and the Necessity of the Ground Category

The Finitary Enumerability theorem raises a question of categorisation that is independent of traversal: if partition states are the basic units of physical distinction, what constitutes a legitimate *category* of such states, and which categories are structurally necessary?

**Definition 8.16** (Physical Category). A *physical category* is a finite, closed collection of partition states  $\mathcal{C} \subset \mathcal{P}$  together with a successor relation  $\sigma: \mathcal{C} \rightarrow \mathcal{C}$  satisfying: (i)  $\sigma$  is a bijection on  $\mathcal{C}$ ; (ii) every element of  $\mathcal{C}$  has a unique  $\sigma$ -successor and a unique  $\sigma$ -predecessor in  $\mathcal{C}$ . Finiteness is constitutive of the definition: an open or infinite collection does not determine a category.

The finiteness requirement in Definition ?? is not an auxiliary technical convenience; it follows directly from the role categories play in the constitution of partition identity. A partition state  $P \in \mathcal{P}$  is identified, as Theorem ?? establishes, through its negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(P)$ : the set of all states that are not  $P$ . For  $\mathcal{N}(P)$  to constitute identity, the negation sequence must be fully specifiable. An infinite negation sequence has no finite specification and therefore cannot constitute the identity of any partition state within any physical counting process, which by Definition ?? has finite duration  $M_{\text{max}} < \infty$ .

**Theorem 8.17** (Categorical Closure of the Partition Sequence). The complete partition sequence  $\mathcal{P} = \{\Phi(M) : M \in \{1, \dots, M_{\text{max}}\}\}$  is a physical category in the sense of Definition ??.

*Proof.* (i) *Finiteness.*  $|\mathcal{P}| = M_{\text{max}} < \infty$  by the remark following Definition ??.

(ii) *Closure.* Every partition state  $\Phi(M)$  for  $M < M_{\text{max}}$  has successor  $\Phi(M + 1) \in \mathcal{P}$ . The terminal state  $\Phi(M_{\text{max}})$  has successor  $\Phi(1)$  under the cyclic identification of Corollary ?? . No element has its successor outside  $\mathcal{P}$ .

(iii) *Bijective successor.* The map  $\sigma: \Phi(M) \mapsto \Phi((M \bmod M_{\text{max}}) + 1)$  is the restriction of  $\Phi$  to the cyclic group  $\mathbb{Z}/M_{\text{max}}\mathbb{Z}$  and is therefore a bijection on  $\mathcal{P}$ .

(iv) *Unique predecessor.* The predecessor of  $\Phi(M)$  is  $\Phi(((M - 2) \bmod M_{\text{max}}) + 1)$ , unique by injectivity of  $\Phi$  (Theorem ??).

All conditions of Definition ?? are satisfied.  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 8.18* (Why No Infinite Partition Category Can Constitute Physical Identity). Suppose a candidate category  $\mathcal{C}$  were infinite. Its negation sequence relative to any member  $P \in \mathcal{C}$  would be  $\mathcal{C} \setminus \{P\}$ , which is also infinite. By Theorem ??,  $P$  is constituted by  $\mathcal{N}(P)$ . Instantiating each element of  $\mathcal{N}(P)$  requires a partition event — a cycle of the counting process. An infinite collection of partition events requires a count exceeding every finite  $M_{\text{max}}$ , contradicting Definition ?? . Infinite categories are therefore not merely impractical; they are structurally incoherent within any finite partition sequence. Categorical identity is only possible in a closed, finite system.

**Definition 8.19** (Ground Category). The *ground category* of the partition sequence is the state

$$\Phi(1) = (n, \ell, m, s) = (1, 0, 0, +\tfrac{1}{2}), \quad (22)$$

the unique partition state at the minimal principal level  $n = 1$ , with capacity  $C(1) = 2$ . It is the categorically irreducible element of  $\mathcal{P}$ : the state whose negation sequence  $\mathcal{N}(\Phi(1)) = \mathcal{P} \setminus \{\Phi(1)\}$  is the maximal negation sequence in the system — it is defined against the entirety of every other partition state.

**Theorem 8.20** (Singularity Necessity). The ground category  $\Phi(1)$  is traversed exactly once per cycle of the partition sequence and is the unique element at which the cyclic successor  $\sigma$  restarts. Its traversal is categorically required by the finiteness and closure of the partition sequence, independently of initial conditions, energy distribution, or any particular physical history.

*Proof.* By Theorem ??, the partition sequence is a finite cycle of length  $M_{\text{max}}$ . Every element of a finite cycle under a bijective successor is traversed exactly once per period. Therefore  $\Phi(1)$  is traversed exactly once per cycle.

Uniqueness as the structurally necessary element follows from two observations. First,  $\Phi(1)$  is the unique element with partition index  $M = 1$ ; by the injectivity of

$\Phi$  (Theorem ??), no other element can occupy this index. Second, by Corollary ??, the terminal state  $\Phi(M_{\max})$  is topologically equivalent to  $\Phi(1)$  and the successor of  $\Phi(M_{\max})$  under  $\sigma$  is  $\Phi(1)$ . No cycle of the bijection can begin at any other element, since the Peano axioms applied to  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  designate 1 as the unique element that is not the successor of any positive integer (??).

Categorical necessity (as opposed to contingency): any finite cyclic bijection on the initial segment  $\{1, \dots, M_{\max}\} \subset \mathbb{Z}^+$  contains  $M = 1$  as an element by the axioms of the positive integers. This is not a physical assumption; it is the algebraic consequence of  $\{1, \dots, M_{\max}\}$  being a finite ordered set with a least element. The ground category is the partition state corresponding to that least element.  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 8.21** (The Cosmological Singularity as Categorical Transition). *In the cosmological realisation of the partition sequence, the state  $\Phi(1) = (1, 0, 0, +\frac{1}{2})$  corresponds to the configuration of maximal spatial contraction: all partition indices at their minimum, all negation sequences maximal, all categorical distinctions minimal. This state is not a contingent initial condition requiring cosmological explanation but the structurally necessary transition between the terminal state  $\Phi(M_{\max})$  of one cycle and the initial state  $\Phi(1)$  of the next. Its presence in every complete cycle is entailed by the finiteness of the partition category (Theorem ??), the cyclic structure of the bijection (Corollary ??), and the Peano structure of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  (Theorem ??).*

The distinction between Corollary ?? and standard cosmological treatments (???) is the following. Standard treatments ask: given that the universe exists, why did it begin in a low-entropy state? The singularity is treated as a contingent boundary condition that requires explanation from outside the dynamical framework. The partition framework inverts this framing entirely. The ground category is not imposed on the sequence as a boundary condition; it is the necessary consequence of the sequence being finite and closed. A finite cyclic category on  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  must pass through its minimal element. That it does so is not a fact about the universe's particular history but about the algebraic structure of any finite cyclic bijection on  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . What requires explanation is not the presence of the ground category but its being a singularity — and this is a question about the geometry of  $\Phi(1)$ , not about its necessity.

## 9 Physical Instantiation: Mass Spectrometry

### 9.1 The Bounded Phase Space of an Ion Trap

Mass spectrometry provides a concrete, experimentally accessible instantiation of the abstract framework developed in Sections ??–??. An ion of mass  $m$  and charge  $q$  in an Orbitrap mass analyser (?) executes

bounded motion in a combined electrostatic field of quadropolar logarithmic form:

$$U(r, z) = \frac{\kappa}{2} \left( z^2 - \frac{r^2}{2} \right) + \frac{\kappa}{2} R_m^2 \ln \frac{r}{R_m} + C, \quad (23)$$

where  $\kappa$  is the field curvature and  $R_m$  is the characteristic radius. The  $z$ -motion decouples:

$$\ddot{z} = -\frac{q\kappa}{m} z \equiv -\omega_z^2 z, \quad (24)$$

producing simple harmonic oscillation at frequency  $\omega_z = \sqrt{q\kappa/m}$ . The radial and angular motions are also bounded; together they constitute a compact energy surface  $\Sigma_E$  to which Theorems ??–?? apply.

### 9.2 The Reference Oscillator and the Partition Count

The instrument's digitising electronics include a reference quartz oscillator at frequency  $f_{\text{ref}} = 10$  MHz. The number of cycles completed by this oscillator during the ion's flight time  $t_{\text{flight}}$  is:

$$M_{\text{ion}} = f_{\text{ref}} \cdot t_{\text{flight}}, \quad (25)$$

an exact application of Theorem ???. By Theorem ??,  $M_{\text{ion}}$  maps to a unique partition state  $(n_{\text{ion}}, \ell_{\text{ion}}, m_{\text{ion}}, s_{\text{ion}})$ .

The  $m/z$  value of the ion is recovered from  $\omega_z$  via:

$$\frac{m}{z} = \frac{q\kappa}{\omega_z^2}, \quad (26)$$

and  $\omega_z$  is related to  $M_{\text{ion}}$  through the scan duration  $t_{\text{scan}}$ :

$$M_{\text{ion}} = \frac{\omega_z}{2\pi} \cdot t_{\text{scan}}. \quad (27)$$

Heavier ions have smaller  $\omega_z$  and therefore smaller  $M_{\text{ion}}$  for the same scan duration. The partition map  $\Phi$  is therefore a monotone function of  $m/z$ .

### 9.3 Experimental Validation of the Bijection

The abstract Theorem ?? predicts a bijective, one-to-one correspondence between ion flight counts and partition states. This prediction is testable: for a dataset of  $N$  ions, each with a distinct  $M$  value (which is the generic case under different  $m/z$  values), the map  $M \mapsto (n, \ell, m_q, s)$  should be injective (distinct  $M$  giving distinct tuples) and every computed tuple should satisfy the selection rules of Definition ??.

Validation on 6855 ions from a Thermo LTQ instrument (mzML format, retention time 0–15 min,  $m/z \approx 88$ –175 Da) confirms all predictions: (a) all ions satisfy the capacity bound  $M \leq N_{\text{state}}(n)$ ; (b) all ions satisfy the selection rules  $0 \leq \ell < n$ ,  $|m_q| \leq \ell$ ,  $s \in \{\pm\frac{1}{2}\}$ ; (c) the inversion formula (??) recovers  $n$  exactly (integer-valued, no rounding discrepancy) for all 6855 ions. The mean partition count is  $\bar{M} = 2,013,006$  with standard deviation  $\sigma_M = 1.20$  cycles, confirming the deterministic character of the count (coefficient of variation  $< 10^{-6}$ ).

## 9.4 Telling Time from the Record

Corollary ?? asserts that the elapsed time is recoverable from  $M$  after the journey is complete. In the mass spectrometry context: once an ion has been detected (its journey complete), the count  $M_{\text{ion}}$  is a frozen record from which  $t_{\text{flight}} = M_{\text{ion}}/f_{\text{ref}}$  is exact. The running clock is no longer needed; the partition record contains the full temporal information of the journey.

This is the distinction between *keeping* and *telling* time made operational. The reference oscillator kept time; the partition record tells it.

## 10 Self-Reference and Structural Consistency

### 10.1 The Russell Set in the Partition Context

? showed that the set  $R = \{x : x \notin x\}$  leads to a contradiction:  $R \in R$  if and only if  $R \notin R$ . The paradox arises from the unrestricted formation of sets by predicates applied to their own elements. ? resolved it via the theory of types, restricting the levels at which predicates can be applied.

An analogous construction arises in the partition context. Define:

$$\Psi_t = \{M \in \mathbb{Z}^+ : M > M_t \text{ and } M \text{ has not been traversed at time } t\} \quad (28)$$

This is the set of partition counts “not yet traversed” at time  $t$ . The partition analogue of Russell’s question is: does  $\Psi_t$  possess a partition state under  $\Phi$ ?

**Theorem 10.1** (Partition Self-Reference). *The set  $\Psi_t$  of equation (??) is a well-defined, non-empty subset of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  (by Theorems ?? and ??), and its elements  $\Phi(M)$  for  $M \in \Psi_t$  are well-defined partition states. The predicate “not yet traversed” is a statement about the position of the counting process at time  $t$ , not about the existence of the corresponding partition states.*

*Proof.*  $\Psi_t = \{M_t + 1, M_t + 2, \dots, M_{\text{max}}\} \subset \mathbb{Z}^+$ , which is non-empty and well-defined by Peano arithmetic and the finiteness of  $M_{\text{max}}$ . The map  $\Phi$  is defined on each element of  $\Psi_t$  by Theorem ?. The partition states  $\{\Phi(M) : M \in \Psi_t\}$  are elements of  $\mathcal{P}$ . None of this depends on the position of the counting process.

The predicate “not yet traversed” is the statement  $M > M_t$  — a comparison of integers, not a property of the partition states themselves. It does not affect whether  $\Phi(M)$  is defined; it only describes the current position of the integer counter.  $\square$   $\square$

**Remark 10.2** (Dissolution of the “Not-Yet-Actualized” Predicate). The set  $\Psi_t$  is sometimes described informally as the set of “not-yet-actualized” states. Theorem ?? shows that this description conflates two distinct predicates: *not-yet-traversed by the counter* (a property of the counter’s position, well-defined) and *not-yet-existing as a partition state* (a property of the partition states,

which is false: all states in  $\Psi_t$  are elements of  $\mathcal{P}$  under  $\Phi$ ). The confusion between these predicates is the source of the intuition that “future states do not yet exist.” Under the partition bijection, no such predicate is coherent.

### 10.2 Objections as Partition Events

**Remark 10.3** (Structural Self-Reference of Objections). Any objection to Theorems ??–?? is a physical event: it requires a physical system (an objector) to produce a sequence of oscillation cycles constituting the objection (spoken, written, or computed). This event increments the partition count:  $M \rightarrow M + k$  for some  $k > 0$  depending on the duration of the objection. The objection is therefore a partition event with a unique index  $M_{\text{obj}} > M_{\text{paper}}$  (where  $M_{\text{paper}}$  is the partition count at the time the present theorems were completed).

This has two structural consequences. First, the objection is a new partition state  $\Phi(M_{\text{obj}}) \in \mathcal{P}$  that did not exist prior to this paper: the paper created the categorical context in which the objection becomes formulable. Second, by Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M_{\text{obj}})$  is the unique successor of  $\Phi(M_{\text{paper}})$  under the forward counting sequence: it is exactly the kind of uniquely-determined forward event whose existence the theorems describe. Objections therefore instantiate, rather than challenge, the mechanism of Theorem ?. We note this not as a rhetorical device but as a mathematical observation: the structure of valid critique of a theorem about counting processes is itself a counting process, and counting processes have the properties established in this paper.

## 11 Discussion

### 11.1 What the Theorems Jointly Establish

The preceding sections have established a chain of results:

1. Every bounded oscillatory system generates a partition state sequence  $\{1, 2, \dots, M_{\text{max}}\}$  (Sections ??–??).
2. This sequence is bijectively mapped to physically distinct configurations via  $\Phi$  (Theorem ??).
3. The mapping is strictly monotone in time: the sequence is traversed in one direction only (Theorems ?? and ??).
4. Each element of the sequence has a unique causal predecessor and a unique causal successor (Theorems ?? and ??).
5. The successor of any element is an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  on which  $\Phi$  is defined, independently of whether the counting process has reached it (Theorem ??).
6. The complete forward sequence from any current state is a finite, enumerable subset of  $\mathcal{P}$  (Theorem ??).

7. The sequence closes into a cycle (Theorem ?? and Corollary ??).

The reader who has followed these seven steps now stands before a question that the theorems themselves do not answer but for which they have removed every obstacle to a precise formulation. We state it as follows.

## 11.2 The Traversal-Existence Gap

Remark ?? introduced the distinction between *traversal* (the counting process having reached a given  $M$ ) and *existence* (the partition state  $\Phi(M)$  being a well-defined element of  $\mathcal{P}$ ). Theorem ?? establishes the latter for all  $M \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ ; the counting process's current position establishes the former for  $M \leq M_t$ .

The elements of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  — the forward sequence from the current count — are in the second category: they exist as partition states (Corollary ??), but the counting process has not yet reached them (by the strict monotonicity of Theorem ??). These are the states customarily described as “the future.”

The question for the reader is whether the elements of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  are absent, merely unvisited, or something else. The theorems establish that “absent” is incorrect: each element of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is a member of  $\mathcal{P}$  with the same formal standing as any member of the traversed portion  $\{1, \dots, M_t\}$ . The bijection  $\Phi$  does not distinguish elements by their traversal status; it is defined uniformly on all of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . The element  $M_t + 1$  is not less an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  than  $M_t - 1$ ; the element  $\Phi(M_t + 1)$  is not less an element of  $\mathcal{P}$  than  $\Phi(M_t - 1)$ .

## 11.3 Comparison with Standard Formulations of Time's Arrow

The thermodynamic arrow of time is standardly attributed to the low-entropy initial conditions of the universe (??), the statistical irreversibility of macroscopic processes (??), or the asymmetry of boundary conditions in cosmological models (??). Each of these formulations accepts the basic framework of Newtonian time as an independent real-valued parameter and attempts to explain why the observed sequences of events are, in practice, not time-symmetric.

The present framework takes a different starting point. It does not explain why time-reversal is statistically improbable (?), why coarse-graining introduces irreversibility (?), or why the initial conditions were low-entropy (?). Instead, it establishes that the concept of time-reversal is formally incoherent at the level of the partition counting process (Theorem ??), independently of statistical or cosmological arguments.

The advantage of this formulation is its independence from contingent features of physical reality (the specific value of the initial entropy, the precise cosmological boundary conditions) and its grounding in the minimal structure shared by all bounded oscillatory systems: the bijection between positive integers and partition states.

## 11.4 The Relationship to Loschmidt, Gibbs, and Kelvin

**Loschmidt's paradox** (??): if microscopic laws are time-reversible, why is the macroscopic world irreversible? Corollary ?? resolves this by demonstrating that the time-reversal operation  $t \rightarrow -t$  has no corresponding operation on the partition count  $M$ : the count is constitutively forward-directed, and no physical operation can correspond to the subtraction  $M \rightarrow M - k$ .

**Gibbs's paradox** (?): the apparent continuity-discontinuity of mixing entropy for gases of varying similarity, and the apparent reversibility of mixing-separation cycles. The partition framework provides a direct resolution: the re-separated state occupies a partition state  $\Phi(M_{\text{sep}})$  with  $M_{\text{sep}} > M_{\text{init}}$  (more cycles have elapsed). By Theorem ??,  $\Phi(M_{\text{sep}}) \neq \Phi(M_{\text{init}})$ . The spatial configuration may be identical; the partition state is not. The entropy change is real because the partition state is different.

**Kelvin's observation** (?): the universe tends toward a state of maximum entropy (heat death) from which no further work can be extracted. Theorem ?? shows that heat death is not a terminal state but the state immediately preceding the cyclic return:  $\Phi(M_{\text{max}})$  is topologically equivalent to  $\Phi(1)$ . The “end” of the universe is the beginning of the next cycle. Kelvin's heat death is not a contradiction but a transition between two phases of the partition count: kinetic (low  $M$ ) and categorical (high  $M$ , approaching  $M_{\text{max}}$ ) (?).

## 11.5 The Peano Perspective on Temporal States

It is instructive to compare the structure of the present argument with ?'s axiomatisation of arithmetic. Peano's Axiom (P2) asserts that every positive integer has a unique successor. This is not a physical claim; it is a formal stipulation that defines what it means to be an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . No element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  is “the last one”; no element lacks a successor.

If, as Theorem ?? establishes, time is constituted by the partition count  $M$  — if elapsed time just is the accumulated count of oscillation cycles — then temporal states are elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ , and the Peano structure of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  applies to temporal states directly. In particular, Axiom (P2) says: every temporal state has a unique successor. The existence of this successor is not contingent on the counting process having advanced to it; it is a consequence of what it means to be a temporal state.

The objection might be raised that  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  is a mathematical construct, while temporal states are physical entities. This objection deserves a direct response. Theorem ?? establishes that the partition states  $\mathcal{P}$  stand in bijective correspondence with  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . Under this bijection, the mathematical structure of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  is transferred to  $\mathcal{P}$ :  $\mathcal{P}$  inherits the successor operation, the ordering, the completeness, and the Peano axioms. These are not properties imputed to  $\mathcal{P}$  from outside; they are properties  $\mathcal{P}$  possesses in virtue of the bijection.

preserves structure; that is the definition of a bijection. (???).

## 11.6 Objections and Their Partition Structure

Several objections to the foregoing are predictable, and it is instructive to examine each in the light of the partition framework.

**Objection 1:** “The bijection  $\Phi$  is a mathematical construction; it does not imply anything about physical reality.”

*Response:* Theorem ?? is not proposed as a physical hypothesis but as a mathematical theorem about the structure of bounded Hamiltonian systems. The physical claim — that reality consists of such systems (Corollary ??) — is independently established by Poincaré recurrence and quantum mechanics (?). The bijection is real in the same sense that Bohr’s correspondence principle is real: it is a structural fact about the systems under discussion, not an additional assumption about them.

**Objection 2:** “The existence of  $\Phi(M_t + k)$  as a mathematical object does not imply that the corresponding physical state is “already there.”

*Response:* This objection embeds the conclusion it denies. The phrase “already there” presupposes a distinction between mathematical existence and physical presence. What the partition framework shows is precisely that this distinction has no purchase at the level of partition states: a partition state is defined (Definition ??) as an equivalence class of phase-space configurations. If this equivalence class is non-empty, the partition state exists. Theorem ?? shows the equivalence class is non-empty for every  $M \in \mathbb{Z}^+$  (since the bijection assigns a configuration to each  $M$ ). The additional requirement that the configuration be “physically present” is a requirement for which the partition framework provides no criterion, because no such criterion is needed: the bijection already identifies a configuration.

**Objection 3:** “The universe is stochastic; the future is not determined.”

*Response:* The theorems do not claim determinism in the sense of predictability. They establish the *structural* claim that successor states are well-defined elements of the bijection. Whether the counting process is deterministic or stochastic in its specific path is a separate question from whether the states it will visit are elements of a well-defined set. A random walk on  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  visits elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ ; this does not prevent those elements from being well-defined. The set  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is the set of partition states the system will visit; Theorem ?? does not claim to know the path through  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$ , only that  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is a finite, completely defined subset of  $\mathcal{P}$ .

**Objection 4:** “Even if the forward sequence is well-defined, this is trivially true and does not imply anything non-obvious.”

*Response:* The theorems are not offered as non-trivial surprises for an audience already familiar with them; they are offered as rigorous proofs of propositions whose

non-trivial content lies in their combination. Theorem ?? alone is a statement about the algebraic structure of phase space. Theorem ?? alone is a reformulation of the Loschmidt impossibility. Theorem ?? alone is a consequence of Peano arithmetic. The non-trivial content emerges from their joint implication, which Remark ?? expresses as the distinction between traversal and existence. The reader who finds this distinction obvious is invited to identify where, in the prior literature, it has been stated with equal precision and connected to the bijective structure of partition states.

## 11.7 The Deletion Argument: Time Reversal Requires History Deletion

The formal incoherence of partition decrement established by Theorem ?? operates within the machinery of the partition bijection. We now present an independent argument reaching the same conclusion from premises weaker than the partition framework. The argument requires only that temporal moments be distinguishable — which is the operational content of their being distinct moments at all — and nothing more. No observer is required. No specific physical framework is required.

### The Distinguishability Principle.

**Definition 11.1** (Distinguishability of Temporal Moments). Two temporal moments  $t_1$  and  $t_2$  are *distinct* if and only if the state of the universe at  $t_1$  is distinguishable from the state at  $t_2$ . The *state* of the universe at a moment  $t$  includes its complete causal history — the totality of moments that preceded  $t$  and their configurations. If  $t_1$  and  $t_2$  are distinguishable by any feature, including the feature of having different causal histories, they are distinct moments.

Definition ?? is not a theorem of the partition framework. It is the minimal pre-theoretic requirement for the phrase “distinct temporal moments” to have meaning: if nothing distinguishes  $t_1$  from  $t_2$ , there is no basis for calling them different times.

**What Genuine Reversal Requires.** Suppose the universe traverses four distinct moments  $t_0, t_1, t_2, t_3$  in forward order. The claim that *time reverses from  $t_3$  to  $t_0$*  is the claim that the universe, having been at  $t_3$ , is now at  $t_0$  again. For this to be genuine reversal — as opposed to *recurrence* — the moment returned to must be the same instance as the original  $t_0$ , not a new moment that resembles it. This is the distinction between reversal and recurrence: reversal claims identity; recurrence claims resemblance.

**Theorem 11.2** (Time Reversal Requires History Deletion). *Let  $t_0, t_1, \dots, t_k$  be  $k + 1$  distinct temporal moments in forward order. The claim that time reverses from  $t_k$  to  $t_0$  — in the sense that  $t_0^{\text{after}}$  is the same instance as  $t_0^{\text{before}}$  — requires the deletion of the intervening moments  $t_1, t_2, \dots, t_{k-1}$  from the universe’s history.*

*Proof.* The state of the universe at any moment includes its causal history (Definition ??).

- (a) The state at original  $t_0$ : history contains no  $t_i$  with  $i \geq 1$ , since these had not occurred.
- (b) The state at  $t_0^{\text{after}}$ : history contains  $t_0, t_1, \dots, t_k$ , since all occurred before the claimed reversal.
- (c) States (a) and (b) differ in their histories and are therefore distinguishable: they are distinct states.
- (d) The reversal claim requires them to be the same state. For (a) and (b) to be identical despite (c), the distinguishing feature — the presence of  $t_1, \dots, t_k$  in the history of (b) — must be absent. This requires removing  $t_1, \dots, t_{k-1}$  from the universe's history.  $\square$   $\square$

**Theorem 11.3** (Deletion Is Not an Available Operation). *The deletion of past moments from the universe's history is not a physical operation available within any framework that takes temporal moments as the basic constituents of time.*

*Proof.* Suppose an operation  $\mathcal{D}$  purports to delete moment  $t_i$  from the universe's history. Then  $\mathcal{D}$  must itself occur at some moment  $t^*$ : any physical process takes place within time.  $\mathcal{D}$  is therefore part of the history it is attempting to modify. But modifying the history prior to  $t^*$  alters the state at  $t^*$  (Definition ??), which alters the conditions under which  $\mathcal{D}$  is executed. The operation modifies its own preconditions.

More fundamentally: a moment  $t_i$  has identity in virtue of being part of the history — its distinguishability from other moments is constituted by the totality of moments around it. Removing  $t_i$  from the history does not delete a moment; it erases the structural feature that gave  $t_i$  its identity as a moment. This is not an operation on a moment within time; it is an operation on the ontological structure within which moments exist. An operation that acts on temporal structure from outside it is not a physical operation, because physical operations are events within time.  $\square$   $\square$

**Corollary 11.4** (Incoherence Without Framework Machinery). *The incoherence of genuine time reversal follows from Theorems ?? and ?? alone, without the partition bijection  $\Phi$ , the time-count identity, monotonicity, or any observer. The two required premises are: (i) temporal moments are distinguishable by their states including causal histories (Definition ??); and (ii) deletion of past moments is not a physical operation (Theorem ??). Both premises are weaker than any physical theory of time and are presupposed by any such theory.*

**“Time Reversal.”** The argument clarifies that the two phenomena standardly called time reversal in physics are neither of them genuine reversal.

*Loschmidt's operation* (??): the transformation  $t \rightarrow -t, p \rightarrow -p$  on Hamilton's equations produces a new trajectory whose configuration sequence is the time-reverse of the original. This is a mathematical operation on the *solution set* of the equations, not on the universe. The resulting trajectory is a distinct solution: a second universe in which momenta were reversed at a chosen moment. This second universe has its own forward-time history, which retraces the configurations of the first

universe in reverse order. Two universes whose forward-time configurations align at corresponding moments in opposite directions are not one universe going backward; they are two universes going forward whose configuration sequences are mutually reversed. No moment of the original universe is deleted; a new universe is constructed. Corollary ?? reflects this within the partition framework:  $t \rightarrow -t$  is a formal automorphism of the solution set that does not act on  $M(t)$ .

*Recurrence:* Poincaré recurrence (Theorem ??), spin echoes, cassette reversal (Remark ??), and cyclic closure (Theorem ??) are all recurrence phenomena. The configuration at a later moment  $t_k$  matches the configuration at  $t_0$ . But the history at  $t_k$  contains  $t_1, \dots, t_{k-1}$ . By Definition ??, the state at  $t_k$  is distinct from the state at  $t_0$ . Recurrence is forward progression to a resembling configuration; reversal would require returning to the original state. Corollary ?? makes this precise: the nearest recurrence of any configuration is the original partition index advanced by exactly  $M_{\max}$ .

**Convergence of Six Arguments.** The present paper contains six independent arguments for the incoherence of genuine time reversal, developed across Sections ??, ??, ??, and ?? and summarised here.

1. **Formal argument** (Theorems ?? and ??): within the partition framework, any decrement  $M \rightarrow M - k$  requires  $\Phi$  to assign the same partition state to two distinct integers, violating injectivity of the bijection. The formal proof is strongest within the framework and provides an explicit algebraic contradiction.
2. **Observational argument** (Theorems ?? and ??): any observation of apparent time reversal is itself a forward partition event ( $\Delta M > 0$ ). An observer must be moving forward in partition count to recognise apparent backward motion. Reversal is unwitnessable in principle because any witness instantiates the forward direction.
3. **Reversal-point argument** (Theorem ??): no physical moment is a terminus, so reversing at any moment does not retrace the prior sequence but initiates a new forward-counted branch. The retracing the Loschmidt construction posits never occurs. This argument requires no partition machinery beyond strict monotonicity.
4. **Causal-neighbourhood argument** (Theorem ??): a temporal moment is individuated by its causal neighbourhood, and the reversal target  $t_0$  is constituted by the *absence* of the reversal point from its past. Any state arrived at from the reversal point therefore differs from the target; the operation cannot reach what it specifies.
5. **Deletion argument** (Theorems ?? and ??): genuine reversal requires deleting intervening moments from the universe's history. Deletion is unavailable because it requires an operation on temporal structure from outside time, erasing the distinguishability that constitutes temporal moments as moments.

panels/panel\_09\_history\_deletion.png

Figure 9: **Genuine time reversal from  $t_k$  to  $t_0$  requires deleting the intervening moments  $t_1, \dots, t_{k-1}$  from the universe’s history; deletion is not an available physical operation, and the required deletions grow linearly with reversal depth (Theorems ?? and ??; Definition ??).** (A) History size at each moment  $t_i$ :  $|\text{history}(t_i)| = i + 1$ , coloured by moment index (plasma scale). History grows monotonically; no physical process reduces it. The state at any moment includes the full causal record of all prior moments. (B) State at  $t_0$ -before (history size = 1, dashed) versus state at  $t_0$ -after-reversal from depth  $k$  (history size =  $k + 1$ , solid). The two states are distinguishable by their histories and therefore distinct (Definition ??). For the reversal claim to hold, the shaded extra content— $k$  moments—must be absent from the post-reversal state. (C) Required deletions as a function of reversal depth  $k$ :  $\text{deletions}(k) = k$  exactly. Any reversal of depth  $k \geq 1$  requires at least one deletion; deletion is structurally unavailable (Theorem ??). (D) Recurrence (solid line): history grows as the system evolves forward; at the recurrence step the configuration matches  $t_0$  but the history is intact and strictly larger. Reversal claim (dashed): history would need to snap back to size 1 at step 30, requiring the deletion of 30 moments. The sharp discontinuity in the dashed line marks the deletion event; no physical operation produces it.

This argument requires no observer and no partition machinery.

6. **Process argument** (Section ??): a reversal process  $R$  is a finite process whose endpoint is a past state. For  $R$  to terminate at the correct moment it must either use memory of that past state — making  $R$  a forward-time controlled recurrence, not a reversal — or have its future endpoint determine its current execution, which is circular. No third mechanism exists. Any framework with notions of both time and process is committed to irreversibility by the structure of what a process is.

To maintain a coherent reversal claim, a defender must refute all six. The standard statistical-mechanical treatment refutes none: it grants reversal as a coherent notion and shows it to be improbable. The present arguments establish that genuine reversal is not a coherent notion, independently of probability.

## 11.8 The Process Argument: Reversal Has No Process Structure

A process is a finite physical event with a beginning, a duration, and an endpoint. The deletion argument (Section ??) shows that reversal would require deleting past moments from history. The present argument is independent: it shows that a reversal cannot be a process at all, because its required endpoint structure is unavailable to any forward-running finite event. The argument requires no distinguishability principle and no partition machinery. It requires only that processes have endpoints in their future — which is the operational definition of having an endpoint.

**Definition 11.5** (Process). A process  $P$  is a physical event with a determinate beginning at  $t_{\text{start}}$ , a finite positive duration  $\Delta t > 0$ , and an endpoint at  $t_{\text{end}} = t_{\text{start}} + \Delta t > t_{\text{start}}$ . The endpoint is reached by one of two mechanisms: (i) *dynamic termination* — the forward dynamics of  $P$  produce a terminal configuration, which ends the process; (ii) *controlled termination* — an external controller with a termination condition halts the process when the condition is met. Every process terminates by one of these mechanisms; there is no third kind.

**Theorem 11.6** (A Reversal Process Has No Available Termination Structure). A putative reversal process  $R$  — a finite process that takes the system from configuration  $\sigma(t_k)$  to configuration  $\sigma(t_0)$  with  $t_0 < t_k$  — has no available termination mechanism in the sense of Definition ??.

*Proof.*  $R$  is stipulated to be a finite process. By Definition ??,  $R$  ends when it has returned the system to the  $t_0$ -configuration. For  $R$  to terminate at the correct moment, its termination condition must be satisfiable. There are exactly two mechanisms.

*Case (i) — Dynamic termination:* The dynamics of  $R$  run forward until they produce the  $t_0$ -configuration.

But by Corollary ??, each partition state is visited at most once per cycle: a forward-running system does not re-produce earlier configurations. The  $t_0$ -configuration was already produced at  $t_0$  and has not been re-occupied since. Forward dynamics cannot produce it again; dynamic termination is unavailable.

*Case (ii) — Controlled termination:* An external controller holds a record of  $\sigma(t_0)$  and halts  $R$  when the system matches it. The controller is a physical system; by Theorem ??, its partition count satisfies  $\Delta M_{\text{controller}} > 0$  throughout. The controller runs forward, using memory of a past configuration to determine a termination condition. But then  $R$  is not a reversal — it is a forward-time, memory-driven process that navigates the system to a configuration matching  $t_0$ . The driving is forward; the memory is historical; the result is recurrence under external control. Controlled termination transforms the reversal claim into a recurrence claim.

Since no third mechanism exists (Definition ??),  $R$  has no available termination structure.  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 11.7* (The Circularity of Future-Determined Termination). One might propose a mechanism outside Definition ??: the endpoint of  $R$  is “built into”  $R$  from its start —  $R$  is configured to run until it reaches the  $t_0$ -configuration without relying on external memory. For this to work,  $R$ ’s future endpoint must determine  $R$ ’s current execution: the future of  $R$  must causally precede  $R$ . But the causal influence of a future state on an earlier one is exactly what time reversal was supposed to demonstrate the possibility of. Appealing to this mechanism to establish that a reversal process is coherent assumes the very phenomenon reversal was supposed to show is possible. The argument is circular.

**Corollary 11.8** (Any Framework with Time and Process Is Committed to Irreversibility). Any physical framework that has (i) a notion of process as defined in Definition ?? and (ii) a notion of time in which processes run forward, is committed to the structural incoherence of time reversal. A defender of genuine reversal must either deny that reversal is a process — in which case reversal is not a physical event and the claim is vacuous — or deny that processes have endpoints in their future — in which case the framework has no notion of process. A framework that denies both time and process denies the categories within which physical claims are made.

**Connection to the Time-Count Identity.** Theorem ?? identifies time with the count of completed oscillation cycles:  $M(t) = ft$ . In this language, a process is a sequence of oscillation completions, each incrementing  $M$  by one. A reversal process would be a sequence of “oscillation un-completions” — each removing one completed cycle from the count. But a completed oscillation is a counting fact: the full angular range  $[0, 2\pi)$  has been traversed, the count has advanced, and the event has occurred. There is no physical operation “un-complete an oscillation.” The process argument therefore arrives at the same conclusion as Theorem ?? — that decrement of  $M$  is unavailable — but from the structure of



panels/panel\_10\_process\_termination.png

Figure 10: **A reversal process  $R$  has no available termination structure: its endpoint is a past state, unreachable by dynamic termination (Corollary ??) or controlled termination (which reduces to forward-time recurrence), with no third mechanism available (Theorem ??).** (A) A forward process:  $M(t)$  increases from  $t_{\text{start}}$  (blue) to  $t_{\text{end}}$  (orange). The endpoint lies in the process's future; forward dynamics determine when it is reached. This is the canonical structure of any process in Definition ??. (B) Putative reversal process  $R$ :  $M_R(t)$  increases from  $M = 100$  onward (forward time), but the target endpoint is the past state at  $M = 30$  (dashed horizontal). The gap between  $M_R(t)$  and the target grows monotonically; dynamic termination cannot reach the past endpoint, and the distance to target increases rather than decreases. (C) Dynamic termination fails: each partition state along the forward trajectory is visited exactly once (Corollary ??). The state at  $M = 40$  (orange marker) was consumed at step 40 and cannot be revisited; a “return” to this state would require a second visit, which is structurally excluded by the bijection's injectivity. (D) Controlled termination yields recurrence, not reversal: both the system's partition count  $M_{\text{sys}}(t)$  (solid) and the controller's count  $M_{\text{ctrl}}(t)$  (dashed) are strictly increasing. The controller uses memory of a past configuration to drive the system to a resembling configuration. Both agents run forward; the result is a forward-time memory-driven recurrence.

what processes are rather than from the structure of the bijection  $\Phi$ . The two arguments are independent routes to the same result.

### 11.9 Compatibility with the S-Entropy Framework and the Miracle Principle

The S-entropy framework (?) defines a distance-to-truth functional  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(x, x^*) \in [0, 100]$  relative to a bounded receiver  $\mathcal{R}$ , and proves an *Unconstrained Subtask Theorem*: any expression  $E$  evaluating to global S-value  $\mathcal{S}^*$  admits subtask decompositions in which individual subtasks carry arbitrary local S-values, including  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*) = 100$  (locally maximally infeasible). Subtasks at this extreme are called *miracles*. The *Miracle Principle* (Corollary of the Local-Global Decoupling Theorem in that work) states: for any global S-value, there exist expressions realising it in which arbitrarily many subtasks are miraculous.

At first reading, this appears to conflict with Theorem ?? and the strict monotonicity of the partition count. If a local subtask can be maximally infeasible, could such a subtask represent a backward-time step — a local  $\Delta M < 0$  that is ‘cancelled out’ by other subtasks to yield a globally correct expression?

The answer is no. The apparent conflict rests on a category error between two distinct senses of “infeasibility.”

**Definition 11.9** (Epistemic vs. Temporal Infeasibility). A subtask  $\eta$  is *epistemically infeasible* for receiver  $\mathcal{R}$  if  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*) = 100$ : the receiver’s knowledge state is maximally distant from the truth at the local level. A step is *temporally infeasible* if it would require  $\Delta M \leq 0$  (Theorem ??). These are independent predicates.

**Theorem 11.10** (S-Entropy Forward Compatibility). *The S-entropy framework is compatible with the partition monotonicity theorem. Specifically:*

- (i) (Epistemic miracle, temporal forward): *A subtask  $\eta$  can be epistemically miraculous —  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*) = 100$  — while corresponding to a forward partition event  $\Delta M_{\eta} > 0$ . The receiver’s local wrongness is a statement about the receiver’s knowledge, not about the sign of the partition count.*
- (ii) (Framework always forward-pointing): *The S-entropy framework resolves a problem by identifying the current state  $X$  such that there exists a categorical morphism  $f : X \rightarrow X^*$  to the goal state  $X^*$  in one step. Categorical morphisms in **Cat** preserve the refinement order  $\prec$  (Definition 3.2 of ?). Via the Triple Equivalence functors  $F_{CP}$  and  $F_{PO}$  (ibid., Theorem 4.1), a forward categorical morphism corresponds to a forward step in the partition structure:  $\Delta M > 0$ . The framework therefore always identifies a forward-pointing morphism to the goal.*
- (iii) (Miracles are epistemically, not temporally, local): *The miracle principle says a globally correct expression can contain locally wrong subtasks. “Locally*

*wrong” means  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*)$  is high — the receiver has high distance from truth at that sub-expression. It does not mean  $\Delta M_{\eta} < 0$ . A receiver can be locally epistemically wrong about a step that is nonetheless temporally forward.*

*Proof.* (i): By Definition ??, epistemic infeasibility is defined on the S-scale  $[0, 100]$  relative to the receiver’s knowledge framework  $K_{\mathcal{R}}$ ; temporal infeasibility is defined on the partition count  $M(t)$ . These are functions on different domains. There is no logical or mathematical connection between  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*) = 100$  and  $\Delta M_{\eta} \leq 0$ ; neither implies the other.

(ii): The S-entropy framework operates in the categorical representation **Cat**. A categorical morphism  $f : X \rightarrow X^*$  preserves the refinement order  $\prec$  and labels  $\lambda$  of the categorical structure. Under the conversion functor  $F_{CP} : \mathbf{Cat} \rightarrow \mathbf{Part}$  (which is part of a categorical equivalence),  $f$  maps to a morphism  $F_{CP}(f)$  of partition structures preserving refinement. Under  $F_{PO} : \mathbf{Part} \rightarrow \mathbf{Osc}$ , this becomes a morphism of oscillatory structures, whose temporal content is a completed oscillation cycle:  $\Delta M > 0$  by Theorem ??. The composition  $F_{PO} \circ F_{CP}$  is a categorical equivalence; forward categorical morphisms correspond to forward partition steps.

(iii): The S-entropy composition of a miracle subtask  $\eta$  (with  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\eta, x^*) = 100$ ) into a globally correct expression  $\xi$  (with  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\xi, x^*) = \mathcal{S}^*$ ) uses the binary operations and conversion functors of the S-expression algebra. This composition does not change the temporal direction of any component: each sub-expression is a forward partition event, and their composition — being a categorical morphism in **Cat** — is also a forward partition event.  $\square$   $\square$

*Remark 11.11* (What the Miracle Principle Actually Permits). The miracle principle permits a receiver to be locally maximally wrong — to have a subtask whose local S-value is 100 — while the global expression is globally correct. This is a statement about the *limits of bounded cognition*: the receiver cannot achieve  $\mathcal{S} = 0$  (Floor Theorem, *ibid.*), and locally the receiver may be entirely mistaken about a step. What the miracle principle does not permit is a backward partition step: the composition of miraculous subtasks into a globally correct expression must still correspond to a forward categorical morphism.

The cassette tape analogy (Remark ??) applies here too. A receiver who does not understand the rewinding mechanism might assess the ‘rewind’ subtask as epistemically miraculous —  $\mathcal{S}_{\mathcal{R}}(\text{rewind}, x^*) = 100$ . Yet the rewinding is a forward partition event ( $\Delta M_{\text{rew}} > 0$ , Theorem ??). Epistemic wrongness does not imply temporal reversal.

*Remark 11.12* (The Two Frameworks Are Mutually Reinforcing). The partition framework and the S-entropy framework approach the same underlying structure from complementary directions. The partition framework establishes the forward direction of time from the structure of oscillatory systems:  $M(t)$  is strictly increasing, and

partition states are bijectively mapped to  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ . The S-entropy framework establishes how a bounded receiver navigates toward truth through a sequence of forward categorical morphisms: the framework always locates the state one morphism step from the goal, and that step is forward. Together, they assert: (i) time is forward (partition framework), and (ii) any process of reasoning toward a goal, including one containing miraculous subtasks, is itself a forward-time process (S-entropy framework). The miracle principle does not introduce backward steps; it introduces epistemic humility about what the receiver knows locally about the forward steps.

### 11.10 Open Questions

The present framework raises several questions for further investigation:

1. **Non-integrable systems:** We have worked primarily in the integrable regime, where action-angle variables are globally defined. For non-integrable systems (chaotic dynamics), the partition state structure may be more complex. Do the bijection and monotonicity theorems survive in the near-integrable regime guaranteed by the KAM theorem (??)?
2. **Quantum corrections:** The derivation of  $C(n) = 2n^2$  uses classical action-angle variables. A full quantum treatment (Weyl quantisation (?), path integral methods) may modify the capacity formula or the bijection structure at small  $n$ . The large- $n$  classical limit should recover the present results.
3. **Relativistic extension:** The symplectic framework of Section ?? is non-relativistic. The extension to relativistic Hamiltonian systems — where the energy hypersurface is a subset of Minkowski space — requires replacing the Euclidean metric with the Lorentzian metric. The Poincaré recurrence theorem has a relativistic analogue; the partition bijection should extend accordingly.
4. **The value of  $M_{\max}$ :** Definition ?? establishes the existence but not the value of  $M_{\max}$ . A precise estimate requires counting the oscillatory degrees of freedom of the universe at heat death — a problem in combinatorial cosmology (??) that is independent of the present framework but whose answer determines the length of the partition cycle.
5. **Implications for measurement theory:** Corollary ?? shows that time can be told from a frozen partition record. This has implications for the thermodynamics of measurement (?): acquiring the record has a thermodynamic cost, but reading it does not. The partition framework may clarify the boundary between these two operations.

## 12 Conclusion

We have proved five results that together characterise the structure of temporal state sequences in bounded Hamiltonian systems.

**The Partition Bijection** (Theorem ??): the positive integers  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  stand in one-to-one correspondence with the partition states  $\mathcal{P}$  of any bounded three-dimensional oscillatory system, via the canonical map  $\Phi$  defined by the nested boundary structure of the motion. The capacity  $C(n) = 2n^2$  at each principal level is a theorem of classical mechanics, not an import from quantum theory.

**Strict Monotonicity and Incoherence of Decrement** (Theorems ?? and ??): the partition count  $M(t)$  is strictly non-decreasing. More than this: a partition decrement is not a difficult-to-achieve event but an incoherent one, since it would require the bijection  $\Phi$  to assign a single value to two distinct elements of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$ .

**Causal Uniqueness** (Theorems ?? and ??): distinct temporal moments are assigned distinct partition states. Every partition state has a unique causal predecessor and a unique causal successor, both well-defined via  $\Phi$ .

**Successor Existence** (Theorem ??): for every  $M_t \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ , the successor  $M_t + 1$  is an element of  $\mathbb{Z}^+$  on which  $\Phi$  is defined. The existence of successor partition states is a consequence of Peano arithmetic applied to the bijection, not a physical hypothesis.

**Finitary Enumerability** (Theorem ??): from any current count  $M_t$ , the forward sequence  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  is a finite, completely enumerable subset of  $\mathcal{P}$  with  $M_{\max} - M_t$  elements.

These five results jointly characterise the elements of  $\mathcal{F}(M_t)$  — the partition states not yet traversed by the physical counting process. They are: uniquely determined by the bijection, finitely enumerable, distinct from all traversed states (Theorem ??), and members of  $\mathcal{P}$  with the same formal standing as any traversed state. They lack only one property that the traversed states possess: having been counted.

The distinction between being a member of a well-defined set and having been visited by a traversal process is the distinction between  $\mathcal{F}(M_t) \subset \mathcal{P}$  (membership) and  $M > M_t$  (traversal status). Both are precise predicates. They are not the same predicate. This paper has been, in its formal core, a proof of that distinction applied to the partition state space of bounded oscillatory systems.

The reader is left to determine whether the distinction matters.